

Article | 4 September 2026

Webinar: Central banks, inflation, and the rate hike gamble

Join ING's economists and strategists for a live webinar on 9 September to discuss the September round of Federal Reserve, European Central Bank, Bank of England and Bank of Japan meetings. Sign up [here](#)



The world's major central banks are edging closer to further rate hikes this month as the economic outlook improves and inflation concerns prevail. That comes at a particularly perilous time for the global bond market, as monetary policy combines with debt sustainability concerns to push yields ever higher.

[Join ING's economists and strategists](#) for a live webinar as they look ahead to the September round of Federal Reserve, European Central Bank, Bank of England and Bank of Japan meetings. You'll learn:

- Why the Fed is edging towards a rate hike this month – and why the data doesn't necessarily back it up
- How the ECB's September rate hike could be the last
- Why the bar remains high for a Bank of England rate hike – and why rate cuts are still likely in 2027
- Whether the Bank of Japan will pick up the pace of monetary tightening this month
- The impact on FX and the outlook for major currency pairs

Details

Date: Wednesday 9 September

Time: 1430 BST/1530 CEST/0930 ET

The webinar will last 45 minutes, including a Q&A session at the end.

The event will take place online and the waiting room will open 60 minutes ahead of the scheduled start time.

A joining link will be emailed following registration and you will receive a reminder email 10 minutes before the scheduled start time.

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Article | 2 September 2026

ECB preview: How to hike rates without creating more market turmoil

We expect the ECB to hike interest rates by 25bp next week. As long as inflation remains mainly energy-driven, hiking rates further beyond next week would not make a lot of sense and could harm the eurozone economy



The European Central Bank looks set to hike rates by 25bp next Thursday

The stage looks increasingly set for another rate hike at next week's European Central Bank meeting. Not only because some ECB members already advocated for a rate hike at the July meeting, but also because, since then, the eurozone economy has shown an almost unexpected resilience to the war in the Middle East. This is partly due to good luck and to Asian competitors being hit harder by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz and losing orders to European competitors, but also to long-announced fiscal stimulus.

At the same time, headline inflation has continued to edge higher and looks set to stay above 3% year-on-year for the remainder of the year, even if other inflation measures like core and services currently provide no reason to panic. With oil prices remaining elevated and the risk of a fresh gas price shock increasing, it will be hard for most ECB policymakers not to see a clear case for another rate hike.

Even if the ECB doesn't like the term, the second rate hike this year would also fall into the

category of 'insurance rate hike', or maybe more to the central bank's liking: a rate hike to strengthen its credibility and to preempt any possible indirect or even second-round effects from the current energy price shock.

No clear signals from the new staff projections

The new round of staff projections will not bring any significant changes but should remain supportive for the rate hike proponents. Given that the cut-off date for the staff projections is normally some two weeks before the Governing Council meeting, the latest surge in bond yields as well as higher energy prices again will not have played a role in the forecasts. In fact, until a week ago, the so-called external assumptions were almost at similar levels as in the June forecasts.

Against this background, we expect the ECB's growth and inflation forecasts to be revised upwards slightly, mainly due to earlier statistical upward revisions of first-quarter growth and slightly higher oil prices. Base and carry-over effects could lead to marginally higher growth and inflation forecasts for 2027. More generally speaking, it will be interesting to see whether the ECB will also present updates of the alternative scenarios from June. While in July it almost looked as if the ECB's 'milder' scenario could materialise, we are now rather somewhere between the 'base' and 'adverse' scenario.

Looking beyond next week

Whether the ECB will really go beyond a September rate hike is a completely different story. Markets have started to price in at least another hike before year-end, and views at the ECB seem to increasingly diverge. While an ECB blog article this year supported our own view that the current inflation wave is mainly driven by energy prices and that drivers matter when identifying (and reacting to) an inflation shock, comments by Isabel Schnabel and Irish central bank governor Gabriel Makhlouf hint at a clear willingness to hike further.

However, with one additional rate hike (next week), the deposit rate at 2.5% would still be within the range the ECB itself calls neutral. Going further would mean that the ECB sees restrictive monetary policy as necessary. But there is a big difference between an economy that has shown resilience and an overheating economy that needs restrictive monetary policy. We still find it hard to see – amid public finance woes and surging bond yields – that the ECB would really be willing to add more fuel to the fire. Or in other words, it's difficult to envisage the ECB being willing to risk a recession to tackle what is still a textbook supply-side shock.

ECB's reaction to the recent surge in bond yields

Another topic for next week's ECB meeting and the following press conference will be the latest surge in bond yields – and, related to this, concerns about debt sustainability in Europe (and

elsewhere). At first glance, this surge is actually coming in handy for the ECB. Bond markets are doing the ECB's job, i.e., tightening financing conditions. According to macro models, a 50bp increase in bond yields has a slightly larger impact on inflation and GDP growth than a 50bp increase in the ECB's policy rate.

Consequently, the main challenge for the central bank will be not to add too much fuel to the fire. Remember the unwarranted tightening of financing conditions. In fact, as long as inflation is not under control, it is not so much the absolute level of long-term interest rates but rather the spread between eurozone countries that is of most concern for the ECB. Some tightening of financing conditions can ease the ECB's job; too much tightening, and unequal tightening, would bring new problems.

This is why questions may eventually arise as to whether the ECB would be willing to restart asset purchases, now under the label of the Transmission Protection Instrument. Let's be clear, this is not a debate for now. But if debt sustainability concerns grow, possibly ahead of next year's French presidential elections, markets might want to test the ECB. We have seen it before. In this context, a debate that has so far been confined largely to the yellow press might become more policy-relevant: the possibility of an early exit for Christine Lagarde as ECB president and the question of who would be her successor. Some of the names of possible candidates currently circulating have, at least in the past, not been strong supporters of quantitative easing.

All in all, we expect the ECB to hike interest rates by 25bp next week. Another insurance rate hike. Or for those who don't like this term: a dovish rate hike.

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THINK Economic and financial analysis

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Article | 4 September 2026

UNITED STATES

US jobs report beats all expectations, boosts case for a September hike

The US added 162,000 jobs in August, above all expectations in the market, with an additional 55,000 of upward revisions to the past two months. With Fed Chair Kevin Warsh describing the US at full employment, this outcome has nudged expectations of a September rate hike higher, but the final decision hangs on next Friday's inflation print



The August jobs report was stronger than expected, with construction one of the bright spots. The stronger number could result in a September rate hike, but we still have next week's inflation numbers

162,000

US jobs added in August

Better than expected

Solid job gains, unemployment stays low

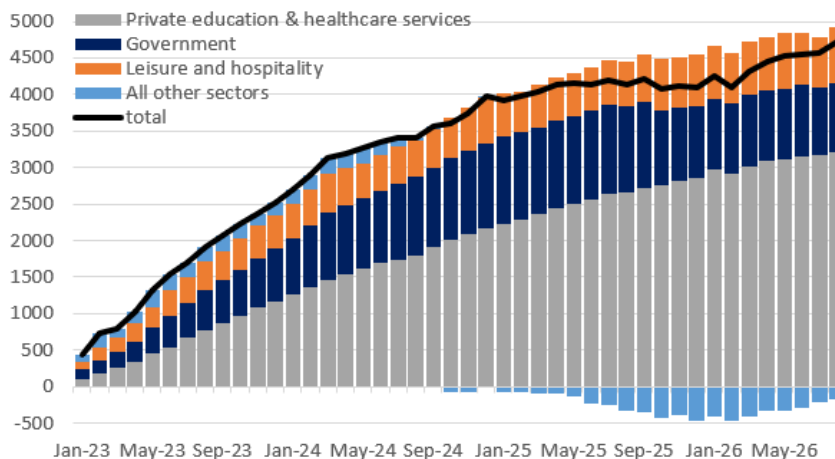
Today has seen the release of a strong US August jobs report that makes a September Fed

interest rate hike look a [little more likely](#). NFPs rose 162k with 55k of upward revisions to the past two months. Expectations were for just a 55k rise in total. The unemployment rate remains unchanged at 4.1% despite an improvement in the participation rate. Wage growth is benign, rising 3.1% year-on-year.

The details show the private sector contributing 127k of the 162k total new jobs, with leisure and hospitality rebounding 62k after two consecutive down months and private education & healthcare adding 29k. Construction added 22k and manufacturing added 16k. Government was also firm despite small drops in federal and state government employment. Instead, it was local government education, which rose 42k that led the charge. That is a surprise given media coverage of falling pupil enrolment and supposed lay-offs in the sector.

Jobs growth continues to be dominated by just three sectors – private education and healthcare services, government and leisure and hospitality. This concentrated story is underscored by the fact that cumulatively, all other sectors of the economy have lost jobs since the end of 2022. That is a remarkable situation given the strength of GDP growth seen over that period and implies big productivity gains and reinforces the message about robust corporate profitability in the United States.

Cumulative increase in employment since December 2022 (000s)



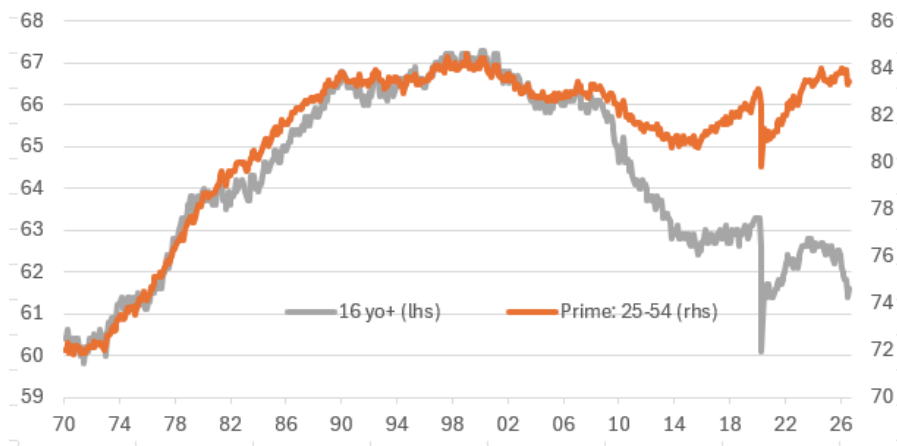
Source: Macrobond, ING

Labour force participation remains worryingly weak

In terms of the household survey, used to calculate the unemployment rate, it showed a 569k increase in employment and a 115k increase in unemployment facilitated by a 683k increase in the civilian labour force. This is a partial correction to a startling trend of people leaving the workforce. Ten months ago, the participation rate was up at 62.6%, falling to 61.4% in July, but

now back to 61.6%.

Labour force participation (%)



Source: Macrobond, ING

A soft inflation print could still tempt the Fed to hold steady

Unsurprisingly, the market has moved to price 16bp of a 25bp rate hike, up from 12.5bp yesterday after Fed Governor Waller's relatively dovish comments whereby he suggested a soft inflation print could mean he votes for stable policy. Next Friday's CPI report will indeed be the key decider and the 0.4% month-on-month increase in headline prices and a 0.2% increase in core (ex food and energy) prices, which is what both we and the consensus predict, is probably not cool enough to prevent Warsh nudging the rest of the FOMC into a hike.

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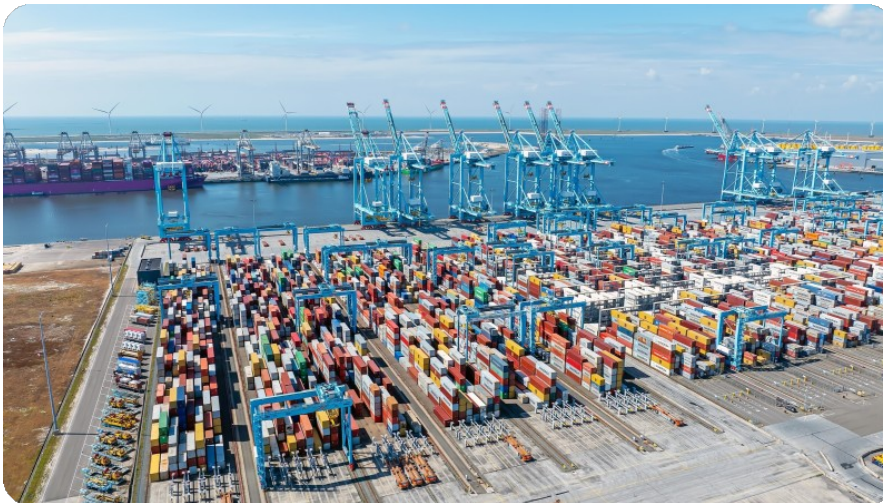
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Article | 3 September 2026

Europe's search for a new growth model

The external environment that sustained the eurozone's export-led model for decades has changed for good. This means that the growth engine can now rebalance towards domestic demand or benefit from a reinvented export edge. Neither comes with a clear-cut playbook, and both can go horribly wrong



Rotterdam port in the Netherlands is the largest port in Europe

Why change a winning team?

Europe's economic model worked so well for so long that changing it never felt particularly urgent. For decades, Europe was one of the biggest beneficiaries of globalisation. Trade became an ever-larger part of the economy, companies gained access to fast-growing markets abroad, and consumers benefited from cheap imports.

Calls for more innovation, higher productivity and stronger competitiveness never disappeared, but they rarely moved beyond strategy papers and political ambitions. Why change a winning team? The Lisbon Strategy of 2000, which promised to make Europe "the most competitive and dynamic knowledge-based economy in the world" by 2010, is a useful reminder of how long Europe has been discussing today's challenges. And of how little discussion alone achieves.

The discussion has since become even more pressing. The Russian invasion of Ukraine and the energy crisis have pushed up production costs, while Chinese firms have become increasingly competitive in industries that Europe once regarded as its natural strengths. At the same time,

global trade has become less predictable and more politicised.

The effects are increasingly visible in trade flows. Since 2019, eurozone imports from China have grown by around 50% while exports to China have declined, widening the eurozone goods trade deficit with China by more than €150bn. But bilateral trade balances should not be confused with competitiveness. To assess competitiveness, it is more useful to look at market shares. Here too, the picture has deteriorated. Europe's traditional strength in machinery and transport equipment has weakened, with trade surpluses shrinking and Chinese firms gaining ground in sectors such as electric vehicles. Even pharmaceuticals, the undisputed bright spot in European trade with exports up more than 80% since 2019, are not immune to growing Chinese competition, as China's share of eurozone imports continues to rise.

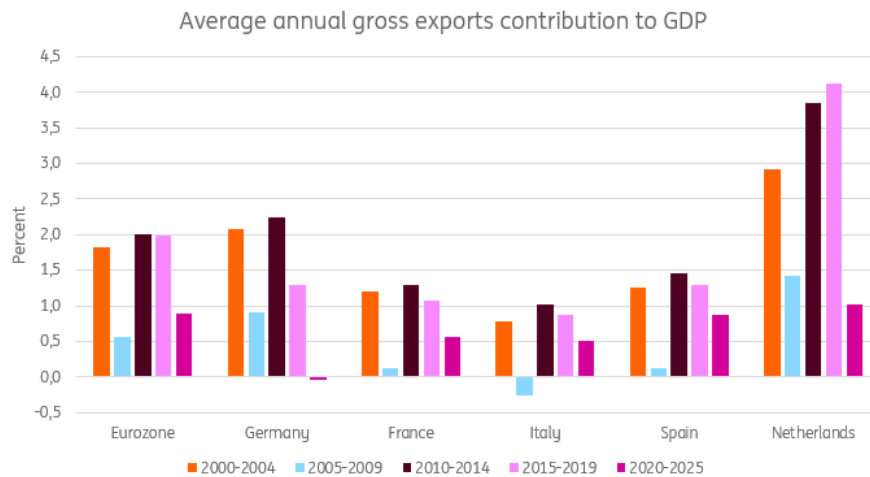
A trade surplus that once seemed entrenched is being eroded by several sides at once. And while a trade surplus is not necessarily a sign of economic strength or something to pursue, the shrinking surplus is illustrative of a deteriorating growth model characterised by manufacturing specialisation, strong external demand, sustained export-market gains and sizeable current-account surpluses. Subsidies, industrial policy and trade barriers may slow the adjustment and buy time for businesses to adapt, but they are unlikely to recreate the conditions of the 2010s.

This is what makes today's competitiveness debate different from earlier ones. While the war in the Middle East and US tariffs have dominated headlines over the past year, they are only one part of the story. The larger challenge is that the external environment on which Europe's growth model relied has changed fundamentally. As a result, the eurozone is being pushed towards a new growth model. The question is what that model will look like.

The engine is sputtering

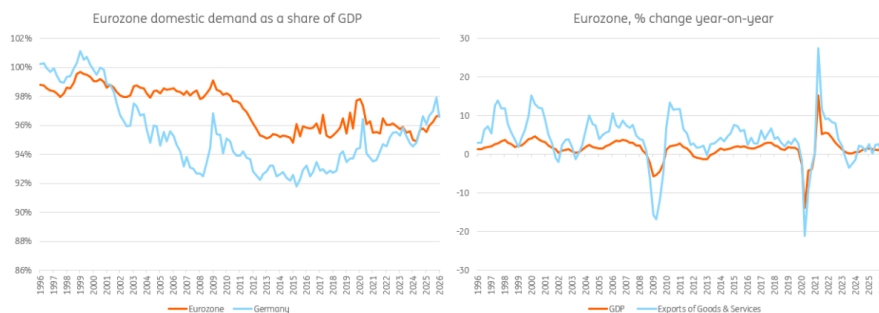
The pressure on the trade balance stems mainly from the export side. The eurozone has become less of an export powerhouse in recent years. To put this into perspective, the contribution of gross exports to GDP was, on average, around two percentage points per year in both the first and second half of the 2010s. Since 2020, that contribution has fallen below one percentage point, and in Germany, of all places, it has turned slightly negative. The Netherlands, the eurozone's most open economy, has seen the export contribution to growth drop to a quarter of its pre-pandemic level.

Contributions of gross exports to GDP have fallen this decade



The same picture emerges over a longer time horizon. Since the mid-1990s, eurozone exports have outpaced GDP growth in every expansion and contracted more sharply than GDP in downturns. Meanwhile, domestic demand as a share of GDP retreated after the financial and euro crises and has never fully recovered. But in recent years, there has been a pickup. And in Germany, this pickup seems more structural. The current expansion is the first in which export growth has failed to outgrow the economy. Of course, there are temporary factors playing a role here, but the structural story behind it is becoming harder to ignore.

The role of exports in GDP growth is moderating



Homemade growth

One possible response to a weakening export engine is a more domestically driven growth model, in which the eurozone's large pool of relatively wealthy consumers and businesses as well as fiscal stimulus become a larger source of growth through consumption and investment. This is more than a theoretical possibility. The eurozone combines high household wealth, substantial private savings and relatively low levels of household leverage with significant investment needs in defence, infrastructure, energy and digitalisation. If these

resources can be mobilised more effectively, domestic demand could become a stronger source of growth than it has been for much of the past decade.

Recent initiatives could give such a shift additional momentum. Higher defence and infrastructure spending, particularly in Germany, are boosting investment demand. The Savings and Investments Union aims to channel Europe's large pool of savings towards productive investment, while policymakers are increasingly focused on reducing barriers within the single market. Together, these developments could provide stronger support for domestic demand than Europe has seen in many years.

But how likely is it that domestic demand can simply take over? It's a clear opportunity, but we don't want to close our eyes to the complications either. Below, we focus on three limiting factors: the lack of historical precedents, the euro, and demographics.

The precedent problem

There are remarkably few examples of countries that have successfully moved from an export-led to a domestically-driven growth model. The United States is the obvious one: a large trade surplus at the end of World War II turned into the historically large deficits of the current era, while the economy kept growing. The dollar's reserve currency role did not cause America's shift towards persistent external deficits, but it made those deficits easier and cheaper to finance than they would be for almost any other country. The US could rebalance on other people's savings.

The other precedents are less flattering. Historical experience suggests that external rebalancing is compatible with solid growth when it reflects higher productive investment, but not when it is driven by credit-fuelled demand booms or declining competitiveness. Or worse, often the so-called rebalancing happens in times of severe crisis. Finland's current account surplus shrank sharply after 2008, but mainly because of the demise of Nokia and weaker export performance; GDP growth fell from around 3% to essentially zero. That was rebalancing out of weakness, not strength.

Spain, Portugal and Greece saw their external balances deteriorate after entering the monetary union as cheap capital fuelled consumption and construction booms. Growth was strong until the bubble burst. Too much of the capital flowed into housing and non-tradables rather than productivity-enhancing investment, leaving these economies exposed when financing conditions tightened after 2008. Ireland was, to a degree, in the same boat as Southern Europe but has recently become more of a rebalancing success story. However, its national accounts are so distorted by multinational activity that both GDP and current account figures need to be taken with a large pinch of salt.

This means there is no blueprint for a highly developed economy to deliberately and successfully transform its economic business model away from exports to more domestic

demand. The eurozone would be entering uncharted territory.

Can a 'global euro' help build a new growth model?

As the US was able to use the dollar's status as the world reserve currency to rebalance, could the euro perhaps be of help as well? A successful rebalancing and a strong euro are best understood as a feedback loop rather than a one-way street. If Europe's domestic investment story becomes credible, foreign capital would flow in and the euro could strengthen. A stronger euro, in turn, raises households' purchasing power, lowers import costs and shifts relative incentives away from exporting and towards serving the home market – which is precisely what a rebalancing requires. This is the mechanism that dollar strength provided for the US for decades.

The loop, unfortunately, also runs in reverse. A weak euro flatters exporters, subsidises the old model and postpones the adjustment – while making imports, not least energy, more expensive for the domestic economy. European Central Bank President Christine Lagarde has been promoting a “global euro moment”. And while the euro's international role has increased modestly (when measured at current exchange rates), it would be a stretch to call this a material shift towards euro assets in global financial markets.

Without deeper and more liquid capital markets, a genuine European safe asset and a larger pool of investable euro instruments, the euro will not get the reserve-currency tailwind that carried the American rebalancing. In short: the currency will not lead this transition, but it is a gauge of where the transition stands. Markets will reward a credible rebalancing with a stronger euro, and punish an unconvincing effort by keeping the eurozone dependent on the very export model it is trying to outgrow.

Ageing makes domestic demand growth more challenging

Demographics are the second complication, and they lean against the domestic-demand story rather than for it. Eurozone population growth is grinding to a halt due to rapid ageing, and ageing societies are not natural consumption machines. Without much population growth, it is a lot harder to increase demand. On top of that, while the theory is ambiguous, we so far see that older households save well into retirement, run down wealth more slowly than the textbooks assume so far, and shift their spending towards services and pharma rather than the goods and housing that drive investment cycles. The effects of ageing on labour supply, potential growth and the composition of demand also make a domestically-led acceleration of economic growth hard to achieve.

Japan is the main advanced market that has already gone through a sizeable demographic decline and its growth model has become more reliant on exports over time. The period of significant ageing of the Japanese population went hand in hand with a rising, not falling, share of exports in GDP although this also went hand in hand with a prolonged balance sheet

recession. As the domestic market matured and shrank, Japanese companies increasingly looked abroad for growth, and the economy as a whole relied on earning income from the rest of the world to fund retirement at home. If Europe's future relied on ageing consumers suddenly discovering their inner spender, this is again something that hasn't really been done before.

In Japan, ageing has come with a rising share of exports in GDP



Source: Macrobond

A second lease for the export model

The lack of clear historical precedents suggests that Europe's way forward does not necessarily lie in a rebalancing towards domestic demand alone. Another possibility is that Europe retains an export-oriented growth model, not by defending yesterday's champions, but by building tomorrow's. Europe remains one of the world's largest trading blocs, home to global industrial leaders, deep engineering expertise and a large integrated market. If these strengths can be translated into new competitive advantages, exports could continue to play a central role in growth. Several candidates for these new export champions stand out. Defence and aerospace benefit from a rearmament cycle that will run for a decade and from procurement volumes that finally offer European scale; Airbus is the proof that Europe can build a global champion when it pools resources. Pharmaceuticals and medical technology are already the bright spot of European trade, and an ageing world is a growing market. Although China is rapidly building a strong position in pharma at the moment as well.

In green technologies, the solar battle is lost and the EV battle is difficult, but grid technology, wind services and nuclear expertise remain contested rather than conceded. Industrial AI and robotics may be Europe's most underrated card. Europe will not out-compete the US or China in AI models, but applying AI to the world's largest installed industrial base - the machine data

of thousands of hidden champions - is a race that is still open. And services exports have quietly become a larger share of the European story, from business services to tourism, with a persistent surplus that rarely makes headlines.

Add to this the recently agreed trade agreements – Mercosur, India, Australia – which could support export volumes, even if their effect on the trade balance is uncertain and likely to be modest.

Still, none of these opportunities are guaranteed. European exporters face higher energy costs, intensifying competition from China, fragmented capital markets and a single market that remains incomplete in important areas. Creating new export champions is therefore not simply a matter of identifying promising sectors. It requires the same ingredients that would underpin a successful domestic-demand story: stronger productivity growth, deeper capital markets, room for innovation and a business environment that allows firms to scale. Not impossible as [we argue here](#), but a lot of work to be done.

Four roads for the eurozone economy

Ultimately, the choice is not necessarily between one model and the other. A stronger domestic economy also breeds more opportunities for European businesses to become global export champions. By strengthening the foundations of the eurozone economy, Europe could support both a more demand-driven growth model and a renewed export advantage. But without a healthy foundation, weaker versions of both could be a realistic outcome as well.

To illustrate this, we define four stylised scenarios for the eurozone as it grapples with the erosion of its old growth model. In these scenarios, the key uncertainty is not whether Europe becomes more dependent on domestic demand or continues to rely on exports. It is whether Europe can generate sufficient productivity growth and new competitive advantages to support either model. A balanced economy without productivity growth risks stagnation; an export economy without new areas of competitiveness risks decline.

	Successful transition	Unsuccessful transition
More domestically driven economy	1. Prosperity at home	2. Stagnant Europe
Export model remains central	3. Industrial renaissance	4. Disneyland Europe

1. Prosperity at home – Europe finds a new growth engine in its own market

Europe deliberately shifts away from dependence on external demand and develops a stronger internal growth model. Initiatives to strengthen domestic demand through public and private investment succeed. A more aggressive shift towards renewables and nuclear power reduces energy dependence significantly, and structural reforms unlock activity. Supported by

the savings and investment union, Europe becomes more attractive for foreign investors; capital inflows strengthen the euro. The wage moderation efforts of the past decades are not repeated as labour becomes more expensive.

Together with the stronger euro, this reinforces purchasing power. Trade surpluses narrow almost automatically – a symptom of success, not failure. Europe imposes import restrictions on Chinese products but keeps the European market open for Chinese investment. While Europe remains dependent on US AI providers, the smart application of AI lifts productivity, and services become a larger share of European growth.

2. Stagnant Europe – rebalancing without renewal

Exports lose momentum and trade surpluses disappear, but Europe fails to generate sufficient domestic dynamism to compensate. Higher commodity prices weigh on purchasing power and ageing and weak productivity dominate. As European exporters lose market share and exports cease to be the main growth driver, the European growth model does indeed become more balanced – but it is a balance of the race-to-the-bottom kind. Productivity remains weak, companies increasingly invest abroad, and the current account balances not because domestic demand rises but because there is less and less to export. Rebalancing by default rather than by design: the Finnish experience at a larger scale.

3. Industrial renaissance – Europe creates the next generation of export champions

Europe retains an export-orientated model, but not by defending existing industries. Reforms in the home market allow for better scaled companies. The basis for revived growth is similar to our 'Prosperity at home' scenario. New, globally competitive sectors emerge and sustain strong external demand: defence, aerospace, renewable technologies and pharma, among others. Industrial AI applications and robotics keep European companies at the forefront of global industry, converting the world's largest installed manufacturing base into a productivity advantage. Labour costs are kept under control by wage moderation and technological advancements. The model stays recognisably European – open, trade-oriented, engineering-heavy – but with a new generation of products under the hood.

4. Disneyland Europe – fighting yesterday's battle

Europe doubles down on preserving existing industrial structures through subsidies, protectionism and wage restraint. The export model remains the ambition, but competitiveness continues to weaken as structural reforms stay superficial and half-hearted. Regulation continues to dominate AI implementation, keeping potential productivity gains low. This is the worst-case scenario: a continued, gradual deterioration of prosperity in which Europe's most reliable growth industry becomes showing tourists from Asia and America what a great economy once looked like. Culture and history, after all, are harder to ruin than economic prosperity.

Le roi est mort – but where is the heir?

The old European growth model will not be voted out of office; it is being retired by the world around it. The real choice facing Europe is therefore not between a domestic-led and an export-led model. It is between deliberate change and change by default. Both 'Prosperity at home' and 'Industrial renaissance' are within reach, and they are not even mutually exclusive – a stronger home market and new export champions could happily coexist. Even if historical evidence clearly suggests that an 'industrial renaissance' would be the model with a higher chance of success.

In any case, both outcomes require the same clear but also disruptive policy choices, in order to achieve productivity growth, cheaper energy, deeper capital markets and reforms that survive contact with national politics. In fact, Europe won't need to choose a new business model upfront, it simply needs to do its homework and then step back to see which model will prevail. One thing is for sure: doing nothing would push the European economy further into its very own 'Nokia' moment.

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Article | 3 September 2026

HEALTHCARE

Trump's MFN policy is reshaping global pharma, not prices

The Trump Administration this week announced nine new most-favoured nation (MFN) deals with mid-sized pharma companies. As the MFN model continues to expand, its implications for the industry are becoming increasingly clear: the US is attracting investment and Europe is losing out. The benefits for American patients, however, are far less certain



The recent most-favoured nation deals are not likely to result in lower prices for US patients, but will bring investment into the US

The US consumer is yet to see a significant drop in medicine prices

The nine new agreements expand the MFN framework to 26 manufacturers, which, according to the White House, covers around 89% of the branded drug market. However, this does not materially alter our core view that the direct impact on branded pharmaceutical margins will remain limited.

We have consistently argued that MFN pricing, which links US drug prices to those paid in other developed markets, does not necessarily trigger broad-based price cuts in the US for three

reasons:

- First, price cuts for current drugs only apply to Medicaid, which makes up just 10% of the US market.
- Second, MFN only applies to new launches and manufacturers can partly manage the reference price by delaying or limiting launches in lower-priced markets.
- Third, it is likely that pricing agreements will exclude medicines that are used exclusively for rare diseases.

Given that the US is responsible for roughly 50% of revenues and often around two-thirds of branded pharma profits, companies have an incentive to delay launches in other markets. The incentive to delay a lower-priced European launch will be strongest for medicines whose revenues depend primarily on maintaining a high price, rather than on generating large volumes at a lower price.

The impact of MFN on prices is therefore manageable for the industry. It is no wonder, then, that we have seen many branded pharma companies raise guidance over the past year, signalling that these agreements generally protect profitability.

But the policy will attract manufacturing to the US

While the direct pricing impact of MFN may be limited, the policy is likely to further accelerate the shift of pharmaceutical manufacturing to the United States. Tariffs and pricing pressures are a powerful incentive to localise production because the US market is so profitable. The nine latest signatories committed at least \$19.6bn in US manufacturing investment, bringing total announced industry commitments since tariffs and MFN to nearly \$670bn.

More broadly, both Republicans and Democrats increasingly view pharmaceuticals and biotechnology as strategic industries critical to national security, meaning that policies that strengthen US control of biopharma supply chains will likely be structural rather than just a Trump-era phenomenon.

Europe faces an access issue and lacks a coherent response

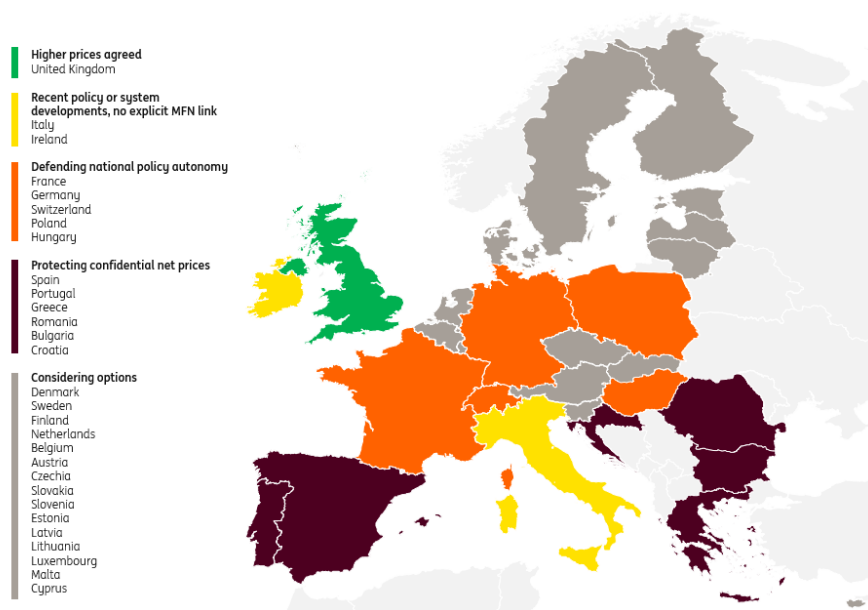
For countries used as pricing benchmarks, MFN means an increasing access challenge. As US prices are elevated, medicine launches in reference countries may be delayed. Through the first four months of 2026, we have seen a decline of 25% in drug applications at the European Medicines Agency compared to the same period last year. Europe, therefore, faces an increasing access issue, which is bad news for European patients.

European policymakers have so far offered a limited and uncoordinated response. Many governments seem to want to ignore the issue, while only the UK has increased its prices for new innovative therapies and Ireland and Italy have recently enacted reforms, though without an explicit link to MFN.

The unwillingness of many European governments to address this issue is understandable given fiscal pressure from increased healthcare and social security spending due to ageing populations and increased defence spending. However, we believe upward price pressure from the American government and the industry will not go away.

Europe's response to MFN has been mostly wait-and-see

EU27 + the UK and Switzerland classified according to their response to MFN



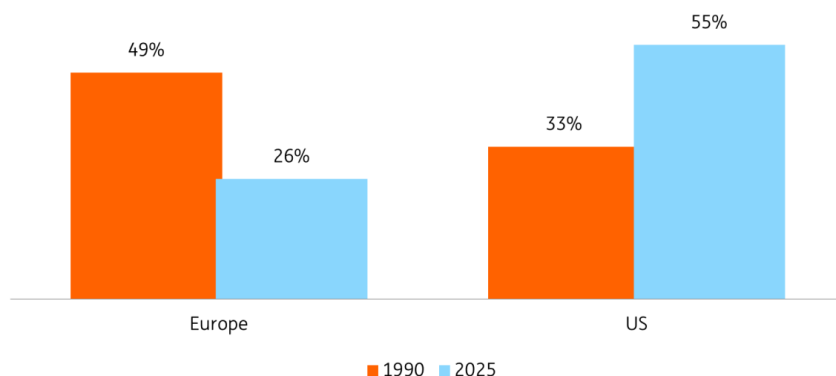
Source: ING

Increasing prices is not enough to fix Europe's competitiveness issue

This means that Europe needs a more coordinated response, not just because of MFN, but also because of the EU's ambition to make Europe [the most attractive place in the world for life sciences](#). In fact, the continent is losing ground to both the US and [China](#): Europe saw its share of global clinical trials decrease from roughly 35% in 2009 to roughly 20% in 2024, and its share of global private R&D has declined significantly since 1990, while the share of the US has more than doubled.

European share of R&D spending has declined rapidly

European and American biopharmaceutical R&D spending as a percentage of global spending in 1990 and 2025



Source: ITIF; ING

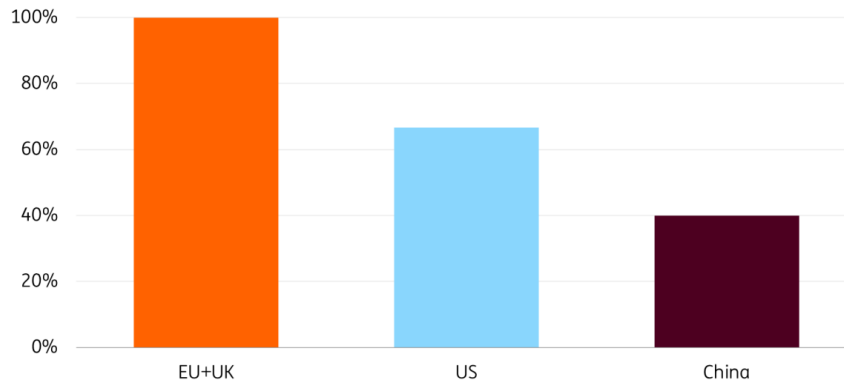
The structural issue at the heart of this decline is not a result of MFN; the policy merely exposes and may intensify longstanding weaknesses in the continent's life-sciences model. In contrast to what many in the industry say, this competitiveness issue is not simply a result of price, but rather of the continent's institutional setup.

Although the EU is technically one market, health policy is still a national policy domain. This means that Europe has a common medicine authority, but still has 27 different Health Technology Assessment (HTA) frameworks, 27 different pricing regimes, and it lacks a common capital market, which means that European biotechs tend to be funded by US venture capital and private equity funds as they mature.

These biotechs then tend to launch in the US because they have to deal with only one regulator and can enter a market of 300 million people and command a higher price, which is why Europe faces a problem commercialising its science. Europe therefore risks losing appeal both as a launch market and as a destination for future pharmaceutical investment, despite the sector's substantial economic contribution.

Europe's scientists are top-notch

Number of citations in top pharma journals as a percentage of 'leader'



Source: ING estimates based on Coface and NIH

The European Commission has correctly identified many of these challenges through initiatives such as the Pharmaceutical Package and the Biotech Act. However, progress at the national level remains lacklustre. As a result, increasing drug prices alone would do little to reverse Europe's declining attractiveness unless accompanied by broader reforms that improve market access, funding, regulatory alignment and the ability to commercialise innovation at scale.

MFN boosts US investment, hurts Europe and offers little relief to drug prices

While the White House presents the latest agreements as a major win for patients and public budgets, the impact on drug spending may be more limited than the headlines imply. MFN savings are likely to be concentrated in specific medicines rather than translating into a broad reduction in pharmaceutical expenditure.

The more significant consequence will be for investment flows: the policy strengthens incentives to locate production and investment in the United States.

As Europe still needs to formulate a coherent response, the region risks becoming a less attractive launch market for innovative medicines and could gradually lose out on future pharmaceutical investment, clinical development activity and manufacturing capacity.

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Article | 9 September 2026

The hidden cost of Europe's preference for deposits

A common perception of European savers is that they are highly risk averse, keeping most of their savings in deposit accounts. But is that really the case? To answer that question, we need to dig deeper and examine households' financial wealth accounts



Deposits remain dominant not because Europeans ignore the benefits of investing, but because liquidity and risk still feel easier to manage in cash

Europeans are beginning to invest more

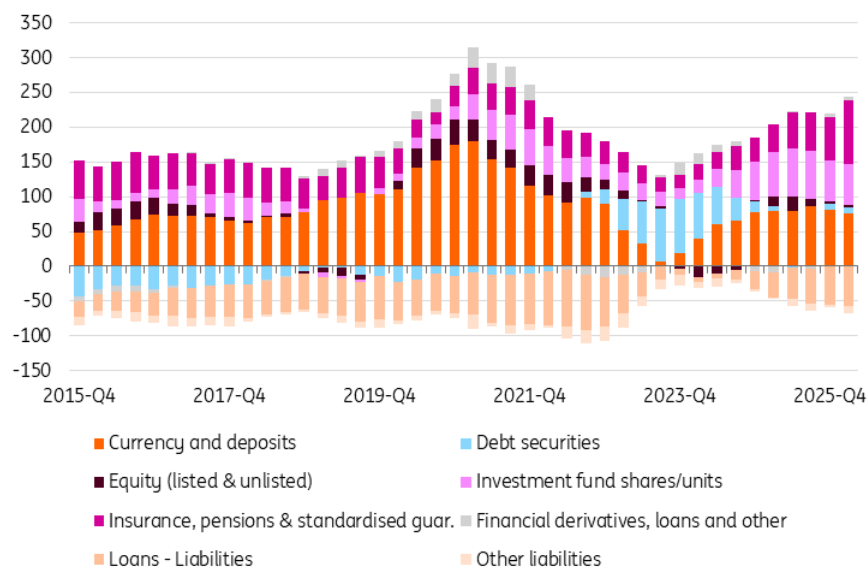
Traditionally, European households have allocated most of their financial savings to deposits and cash holdings, as seen in the graph below. Over 2015-2024, the quarterly flows show that households in the eurozone allocated, on average, almost three times as much of their financial savings to deposits as to investment funds (including ETFs), and seven times as much to deposits as to shares (to enhance readability, one-year moving averages are used).

Since early 2025, a new trend has emerged. Europeans now allocate as much of their savings to investment funds and ETFs as to deposits. In fact, if we look at financial investments in the broad sense (stocks, bonds, funds, etc.), Europeans now spend more money on them on average each quarter than they put into savings accounts.

This marks a striking break with the previous decade, when deposits attracted around 2.5 times as much money as market-based investments. Direct purchases of listed shares have continued to decline, suggesting that the shift is taking place primarily through investment funds rather than individual stock selection.

European savings are starting to move beyond deposits

Eurozone quarterly financial transactions, households (& NPISHs), 1Y moving average, €bn



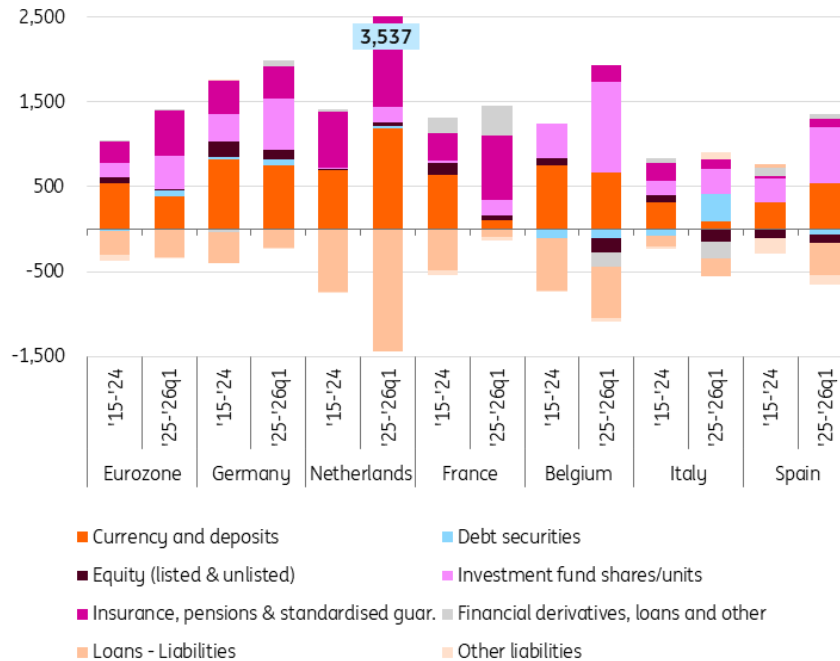
Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

Note: Last datapoint is 2026Q1

The shift is not occurring at the same pace everywhere. In Spain and Belgium, households now direct considerably more of their financial savings towards investment funds than towards deposits. Investment fund flows have also increased substantially in Germany, although German households still place more money into deposits overall. Funds have overtaken deposits in Italy too, but by a smaller margin. French households remain among the least inclined to direct new savings towards investment funds, but have significantly increased their contributions to insurance, pensions and standardised guarantees, which we touch upon [in this article](#).

Investment funds are gaining ground, but not everywhere

Average transactions over period, per household, €



Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

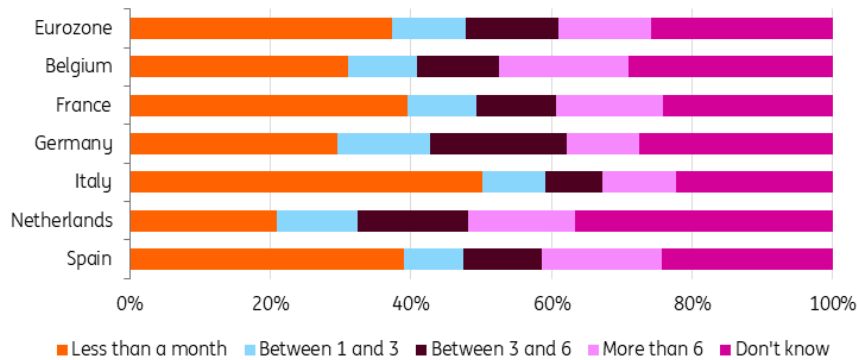
Note: Per household numbers are obtained by dividing the average transactions over the period by the average number of households over the same period. What looks like a spike in pension transactions in the Netherlands for the period 2025-26q1 reflects accounting adjustments in the first quarter of 2026 due to pension reforms from defined benefits to defined contributions

Europeans are cautious, but not opposed to investing

Many households appear unsure of when saving should give way to investing. According to our survey, while 37% of Europeans consider less than one month of income an adequate cash buffer, 26% want more than three months and another 26% do not know how much is enough. For many Europeans, the obstacle is not choosing an investment but deciding when they can afford to start.

Households remain unclear on how much saving is needed before they can begin investing

Respondents answer to: How much do you think a household should approximately keep in liquid solutions, easily accessible such as savings or current accounts, before putting any money into investments?



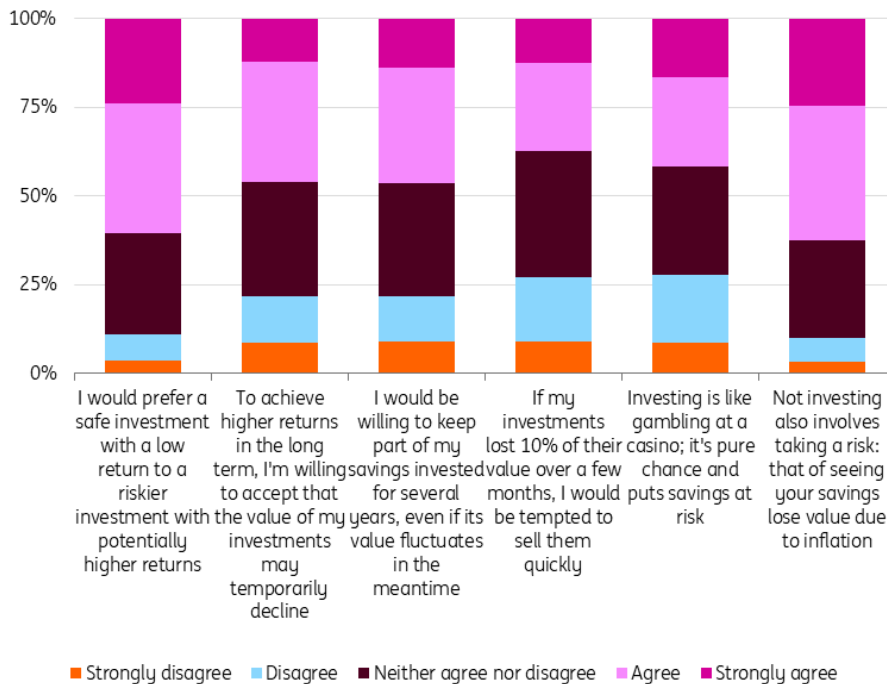
Source: ING Consumer Research

Note: Eurozone refers to the weighted average of the six representative countries

Europeans are cautious, but not blindly so. Although 59% prefer safety and low returns, 46% would tolerate temporary losses for higher long-term gains and 61% understand that inflation erodes uninvested savings. Deposits remain dominant not because Europeans ignore the benefits of investing, but because liquidity and risk still feel easier to manage in cash.

Europeans see the cost of cash, but still choose safety

Eurozone average of respondents answer to: To what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements regarding the risk of an investment?



Source: ING Consumer Research

What European household investments actually returned

Keeping money in deposits protects its nominal value, but limits households' exposure to investment income and rising financial markets.

Using Eurostat's household financial accounts, we estimate the historical total return on eurozone households' investment funds and listed equities. Unlike simulations based on a stock market index or an idealised investment product, our estimates track the portfolios households actually held. They incorporate the valuation gains and losses recorded on those assets, together with income received by investors, after the costs already reflected in the observed returns. The exercise therefore does not assume that households selected the best-performing products or followed an optimal investment strategy. It measures what their investments actually earned.

What €100 invested could have become

Estimated historical total return on the assets held by eurozone households, including valuation effects and investment income

Historical period	Investment funds	Listed equities
5 years (2021–2025)	€ 131	€ 173
10 years (2016–2025)	€ 154	€ 239
20 years (2006–2025)	€ 241	€ 348
24 years (2002–2025)	€ 271	€ 402

Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

Note: Total return combines valuation gains and losses with investment income. For investment funds, income includes amounts attributable to fund shareholders; for listed equities, it includes dividends. Historical performance does not guarantee future returns.

The results are interesting. Between 2002 and 2025, the investment-fund portfolios (which comprise both equities and bonds) held by eurozone households generated an estimated total return of 171%. In other words, €100 invested at the beginning of the period grew to approximately €271, including valuation changes and income received by fund shareholders. Over the same period, €100 placed in deposits by European households grew to €132.5 (+32% over the period, according to European Central Bank data).

Listed equities delivered an estimated total return of 302%, including market value changes and dividend income. €100 invested in 2002 therefore grew to approximately €402 by 2025. The same pattern appears over shorter periods: the portfolios actually held by households generated considerably higher cumulative returns than their initial value, although returns varied by asset class and investment horizon.

These returns are independent of how much households might have moved out of deposits. The size of the portfolio shift determines the amount of capital invested, but not the historical performance of the assets themselves (we take them as a given). The next question is therefore one of scale: what would these returns have meant for eurozone household wealth under a somewhat more investment-oriented allocation?

The macroeconomic cost of playing it safe

Europeans would not have needed to abandon deposits to make a meaningful difference to their wealth. We consider a simple counterfactual: what if eurozone households had invested 25% of the money they directed to deposits each year?

This changes the allocation of new savings, not the stock of deposits already accumulated. The amount reallocated therefore varies with annual deposit flows, while the remaining 75% continues to go into deposits. Between 2002 and 2025, deposits received an average of 48.5% of household financial-asset transactions. Under this scenario, their share would still have averaged 36.4%, or more than one-third of new flows.

Even this gradual shift could have made households substantially wealthier. If the reallocated flows had earned the total return of the investment funds actually held by eurozone households, financial wealth could have been around €1.17 trillion higher by 2025, equivalent to 7.4% of GDP. If invested in the listed equities actually held by households, the estimated gain would have reached €2.79 trillion, or 17.7% of GDP.

The longer the investment period, the larger the effect of income, market gains and compounding. Over 20 years, the estimated additional wealth reaches €810 billion in funds and nearly €2.0 trillion in listed equities. Over 10 years, the gains are around €266 billion and €695 billion, respectively. Even over five years, they amount to approximately €71 billion and €169 billion.

These estimates do not assume that households bought an index or selected the best-performing products. They use the estimated historical total returns of the funds and listed equities households actually held. Each year's reallocated flow is invested at that point in time and compared with what it would have earned in deposits. The reported gain is the difference between the two accumulated values, not the gross value of the investment portfolio.

The results vary with the asset class and starting year. Listed equities delivered higher returns over the periods considered, but with greater fluctuations. Their estimates are also less robust because dividend data does not cover all eurozone countries consistently every year. These figures should therefore be read as an illustration of the historical opportunity cost of favouring deposits, not as a forecast of future returns.

The conclusion is nevertheless clear: Europe's preference for deposits has cost households more than purchasing power lost to inflation. A moderate shift in the allocation of new savings could have produced materially higher household wealth over time.

How much additional wealth could a shift towards investing have created?

Estimated additional eurozone household wealth in 2025 relative to leaving the same annual amounts in deposits (and in % of GDP in 2025).

What if one quarter of new deposit flows had been invested instead?

Counterfactual: each year, 25% of the amount actually directed to deposits is invested instead in either investment funds or listed equities. This shift only concerns new savings. The existing portfolio remains unchanged.

Historical period	Investment funds	Listed equities
2021–2025 5 years	€71bn 0.5% of GDP	€169bn 1.1% of GDP
2016–2025 10 years	€266bn 1.7% of GDP	€695bn 4.4% of GDP
2006–2025 20 years	€810bn 5.1% of GDP	€1,999bn 12.7% of GDP
2002–2025 24 years	€1,168bn 7.4% of GDP	€2,793bn 17.7% of GDP

Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

Note: Figures show additional wealth, not the gross value of the investment portfolio. Historical performance does not guarantee future returns.

Europe's savings could work harder

Europe's preference for deposits has carried a cost not only for households, but potentially for the wider economy. Higher returns could support household wealth and, over time, consumption. Greater participation in capital markets could also direct more European savings towards business investment.

The first signs of change are already visible in the recent rise in investment fund flows. If that shift continues, Europe's savings could work harder on both sides of the economy, building more household wealth while providing more capital for growth.

Note on methodology

The analysis uses Eurostat household financial accounts to estimate the historical total returns on the investment funds and listed equities actually held by eurozone households. The longest calculation covers 2002 to 2025, reflecting the availability of sufficiently consistent eurozone data. The same approach is applied over 20-, 10- and 5-year periods.

Total return combines changes in asset values with investment income. As direct, fully harmonised eurozone revaluation series are not available for every component and year, valuation effects are estimated from annual changes in household holdings that are not explained by net transactions. This residual principally captures market-price gains and losses, although it may also include other changes in volume or statistical classification.

Investment income is taken from Eurostat's non-financial transaction accounts. Income attributable to investment-fund shareholders is measured relative to average investment-fund holdings, while dividend income is measured relative to average equity holdings. Where country-level observations are unavailable, annual income yields are estimated from the reporting eurozone countries and weighted by their corresponding household asset holdings. Dividend coverage is limited in some years, including for several large countries, which makes the listed-equity estimates less robust than the investment-fund results.

The estimated valuation effects and income yields are combined to calculate annual total returns. These annual returns are then compounded to show the historical performance of the portfolios actually held by households. The return series is independent of the size of the counterfactual reallocation.

The counterfactual applies one annual shock to household financial transactions. In each year, 25% of the observed transaction flow into currency and deposits is removed from deposits and invested instead. The remaining 75% continues to flow into deposits. This is a proportional reduction in each year's deposit transaction, rather than a fixed percentage-point reduction in deposits' share of transactions.

Two alternative destinations for the reallocated flow are presented separately. In the first calculation, the flow is invested in the investment-fund portfolio held by eurozone households. In the second, it is invested in their listed-equity portfolio. These are two illustrations of the destination of the same 25% shock, not two different shock sizes.

Each annual contribution earns the subsequently observed total return of the relevant asset class until the end of the simulation period. The same contribution is also accumulated at the return it would have earned in deposits. Deposit returns are derived from ECB household deposit-rate data and combine overnight deposits, deposits with an agreed maturity and deposits redeemable at notice, weighted by the outstanding balance of each category.

The reported wealth effect is the difference between the accumulated value of the counterfactual investment and the value of the forgone deposit position. It therefore measures additional wealth relative to the observed deposit alternative. It does not

report the gross counterfactual investment portfolio.

The average transaction shares shown in Table 2 are calculated separately for each historical period. Consequently, the average observed deposit share and its counterfactual counterpart differ across the 24-, 20-, 10-, and 5-year calculations. For example, over 2002 to 2025, the observed average is 48.5%, and the counterfactual average is 36.4%. Over 2021 to 2025, the corresponding averages are 38.2% and 28.7%.

Financial account values are expressed in current-price millions of euros and converted into billions for presentation. GDP percentages compare the estimated additional wealth at the end of each calculation with eurozone GDP in 2025. Per-household figures are intentionally not shown in the revised table.

The results are historical counterfactual estimates. They are not forecasts, recommendations or expected returns for any particular investment product. Historical performance does not guarantee future returns.

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Article | 9 September 2026

How Europe can turn its investment gap into an opportunity

European households are saving more than they did before the pandemic, but how they save matters. Their preference for deposits over investments has meant missing out on market-driven wealth gains. But rising flows into investment funds recently, together with a large pool of potential investors, suggest this legacy could change



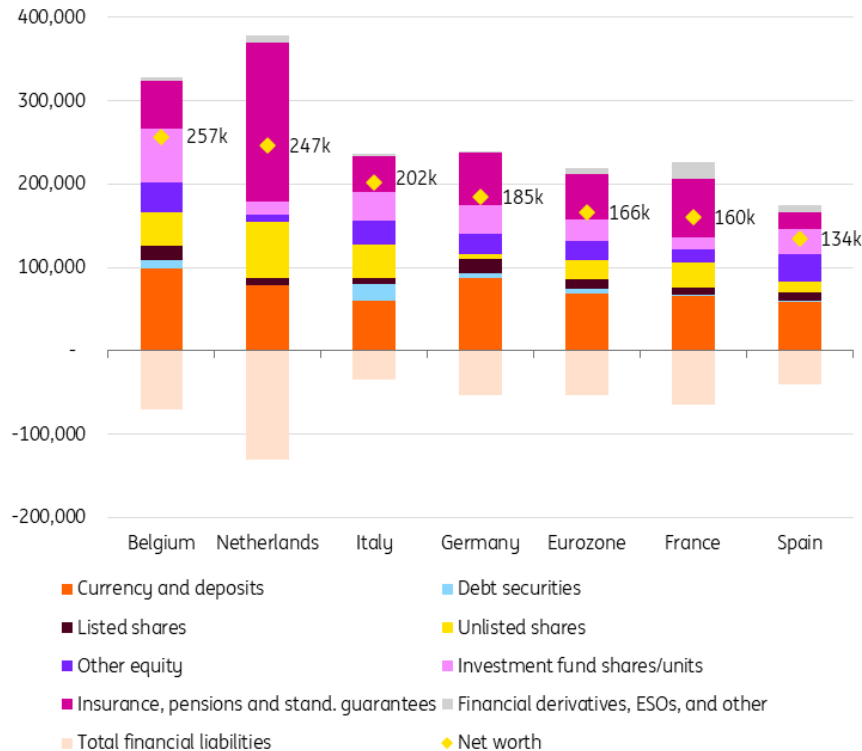
European households have long favoured deposits over investments, but the trend is changing

Past choices are visible in today's balance sheets

Household balance sheets reflect decades of saving and investment decisions, asset-price movements and institutional arrangements. In 2025, eurozone households held almost €220,000 in financial assets per household, including €69,000 in deposits, €56,000 in insurance and pension entitlements, €46,000 in unlisted equity and €43,000 in market-based assets. Average financial liabilities stood at €53,000. The level and composition of wealth differ markedly across countries. These differences reflect not only household investment choices, but also income, demographics, home ownership, taxation and pension systems.

Household financial wealth varies widely across Europe

Financial assets and liabilities, households (& NPISHs), average per household, 2025, €



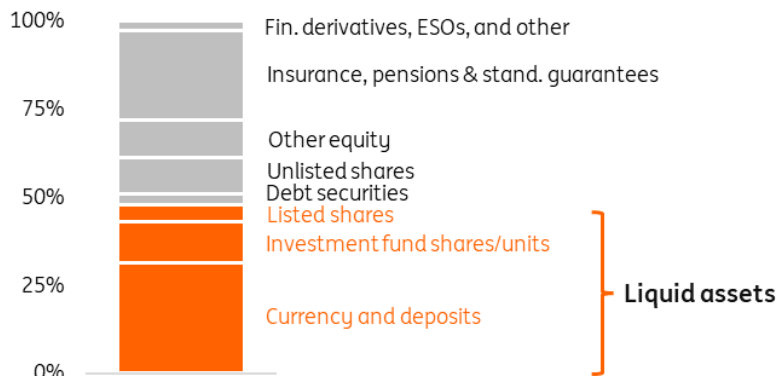
Source: Eurostat, EU-LFS, ING calculations

Note: Average holding is calculated as the total stock in balance sheets divided by the total number of households.

To focus on assets over which households generally have more direct control, we narrow the comparison to currency and deposits, investment funds, listed shares and debt securities. Together, these relatively liquid assets account for around half of eurozone household financial wealth. Deposits alone represent 31% of total financial assets, while the three market-based categories account for another 19%. Of course, pension entitlements, insurance products and unlisted equity are also important components of wealth, but households cannot usually reallocate them as readily as money held in deposits or investment products. The liquid part of the balance sheet therefore offers a clearer view of households' immediate portfolio choices.

Only about half of financial wealth is readily reallocated

Composition of total financial assets, eurozone, 2025



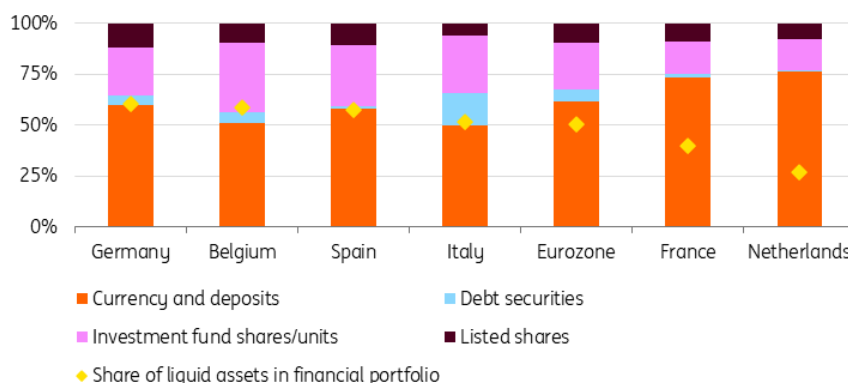
Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

Europe remains deposit-heavy, although the balance is shifting

Within these liquid portfolios, deposits remain dominant. They account for 62% of the eurozone total, compared with 23% for investment funds, 10% for listed shares and 6% for debt securities. The preference for deposits is even more pronounced in France and the Netherlands, where they represent 73% and 76% of liquid assets, respectively. Belgium and Italy hold larger shares of their liquid portfolios in market-based assets.

Deposits dominate liquid assets, especially in France and the Netherlands, where liquid assets are also a smaller part of the financial portfolio

Composition of liquid assets and share in total financial portfolio, 2025

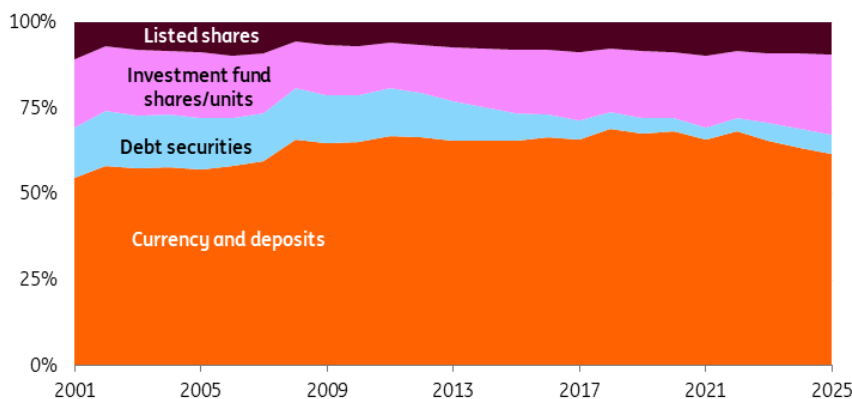


Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

The composition is beginning to change. Investment funds accounted for 23% of eurozone liquid assets in 2025, up from 20% in 2019, while the listed-share component rose from 8% to 10%. Over the same period, the share held in deposits declined from 67% to 62%, its lowest level since 2012. These changes reflect a combination of new investment flows and differences in asset-price performance. All in all, the direction is encouraging, but the legacy of past choices remains substantial.

Investment funds are gradually gaining ground on deposits

Composition of total liquid assets in household balance sheets, eurozone



Source: Eurostat, ING calculations

US households have benefited from much greater market exposure

The significance of Europe's deposit preference becomes clearer when its household balance sheets are compared with those of the United States. Currency and deposits account for more than 30% of eurozone household financial assets, compared with around 10% in the US. In contrast, listed equities, investment funds and debt securities represent approximately half of US household financial wealth, compared with about one-fifth in the eurozone.

Eurozone households hold a larger share of their wealth in unlisted equity. This partially reflects Europe's greater reliance on small and medium-sized enterprises, as household ownership stakes in privately held businesses are recorded as unlisted shares.

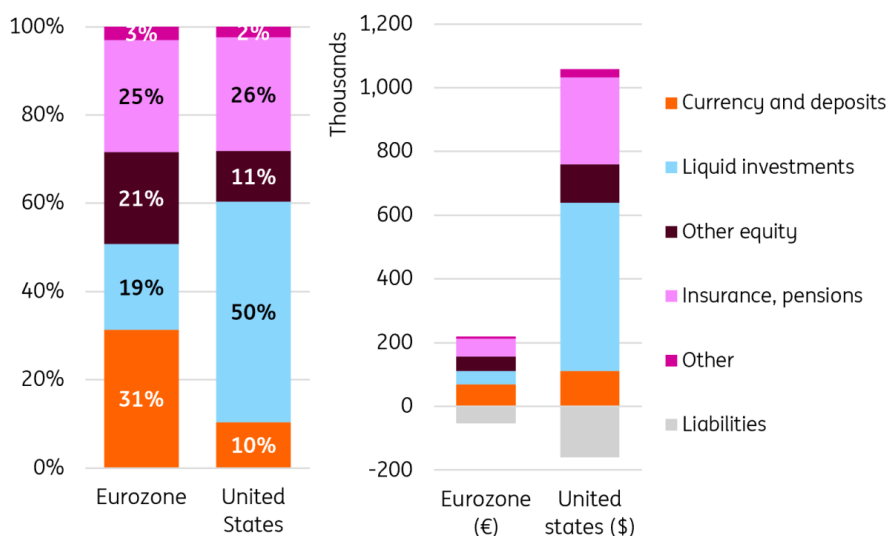
This is not a perfect product-for-product comparison. US households often obtain market exposure indirectly through funds, managed assets and retirement vehicles, while eurozone financial accounts classify shares, investment funds, insurance and pension entitlements separately. The figures should therefore be read as an indication of the broad role played by market-based assets in household balance sheets, rather than as a comparison of identical financial products.

Even with that qualification, the difference in scale is striking. The average US household held

almost \$530,000 in liquid market-based investments in 2025. By comparison, the average eurozone household held approximately €220,000 in total financial assets, including deposits, pensions, insurance products and unlisted equity. After conversion using the average 2025 exchange rate applied in the analysis, average US financial wealth was more than four times higher.

US household wealth is far more exposed to financial markets

Panel A: Composition of balance sheets, 2025 Panel B: Average household holdings, 2025



Source: Eurostat, EU-LFS, Fed, FRED, ING calculations

Note: Liquid investments are an aggregation of listed equities, investment fund shares, money market fund shares and debt securities. This aggregation is necessary as the underlying classifications are not directly comparable. For example, as equities in the US comprise both directly and indirectly held securities and cannot be compared directly to listed or unlisted shares in the eurozone.

Asset allocation is not the only explanation for this gap. Differences in incomes, economic growth, pension arrangements, asset prices and household structures also matter. But greater exposure to financial markets has allowed US households to benefit much more from rising valuations. Investment has not merely changed the composition of American household wealth. It has also contributed to its growth.

The gap is not only about the wealthiest households

Average holdings must be interpreted carefully because financial wealth, and market-based wealth in particular, is highly concentrated. Among US households with direct or indirect stock holdings, the average amount invested in 2022 was approximately \$489,000, almost 10 times

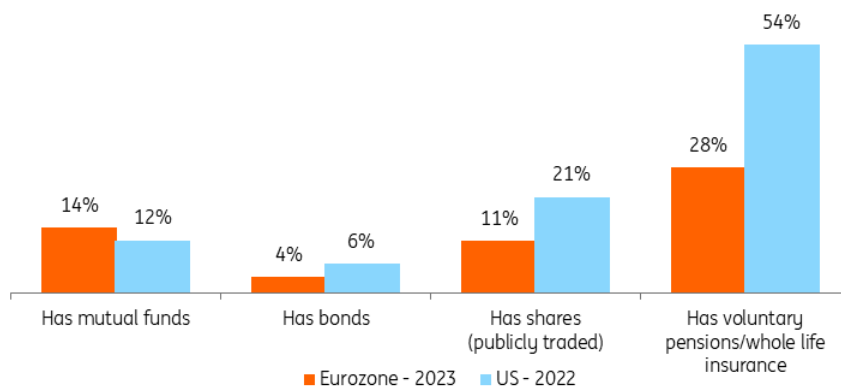
the median holding of \$52,000. This large gap shows how strongly the average is influenced by households with the largest portfolios.

Concentration is, however, not the whole story. According to [Fed SCF data](#), some 58% of US households held stocks directly or indirectly in 2022, including through mutual funds, retirement accounts and other managed assets. The US model therefore combines broad participation with a highly unequal distribution of the amounts invested.

No direct equivalent aggregate measure is available in the published eurozone household finance tables. European statistics ([HFCS survey](#)) report listed shares, investment funds and voluntary pensions separately, without identifying the overlaps between their holders or the exposure to equities within funds and pension products. Product-level figures nevertheless indicate that direct ownership of shares and several other market-based products is less widespread in the euro area.

US investment is unequal, but also relatively widespread

Participation rates in financial assets, %



Source: ECB HFCS, Fed SCF

Note: Assets classifications differ across both surveys, and the closest match is considered. For US deposits, the highest participation rate between holding transaction accounts and certificates of deposit is shown. Bonds consider savings bonds and directly held bonds. Shares correspond to directly held stocks, mutual funds to pooled investment funds, voluntary pensions to cash value life insurance and retirement accounts; and other corresponds to other managed and financial assets.

Europe's investment gap is also an action gap

Official household surveys, however, are published with a lag and cannot fully capture the recent increase in European flows into investment funds. The ING Consumer Survey provides a more current view on participation and intentions. We find that 41% of Europeans say they

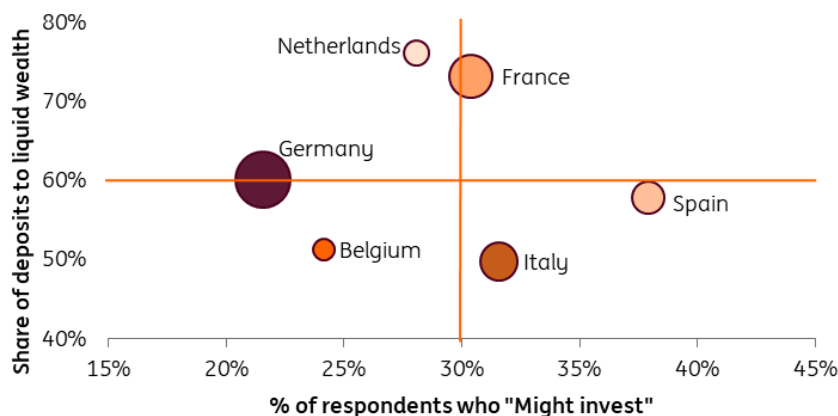
already invest in shares, bonds, funds or ETFs, and 33% do not currently invest but say that they might do so in the future. The remaining 27% say that they do not intend to invest, including a small group who invested in the past but do not plan to do so again.

The most striking finding is the size of the group that is open to investing but has not taken the first step. One in three Europeans are potential investors. In several eurozone countries, potential investors are almost as numerous as those already investing. Europe's retail investment gap therefore does not appear to reflect a widespread rejection of financial markets. For many households, the willingness is there, but it has yet to translate into action.

Germany, France and Italy hold the largest deposit volumes (graph below), reflecting the size of these economies, but they also report higher levels of capital market participation. The Netherlands and France, with their high deposits to liquid wealth ratios, show greater potential of redirecting some liquid wealth into investments, but they don't have the strongest willingness. The best opportunities may therefore be in Italy and Spain, where households show a greater willingness to invest while still holding higher deposits overall, and also a sizeable share of their liquid assets in deposits.

The opportunity to mobilise household savings into capital markets

Amount of allocatable deposits and willingness to invest



Source: Eurostat, ING Consumer Research

Note: The bubble size represents the total amount of deposits in the country. The orange shading indicates the share of respondents who indicate "invest now in shares, bonds, investment funds or ETFs", with darker shades representing a higher proportion who currently invest.

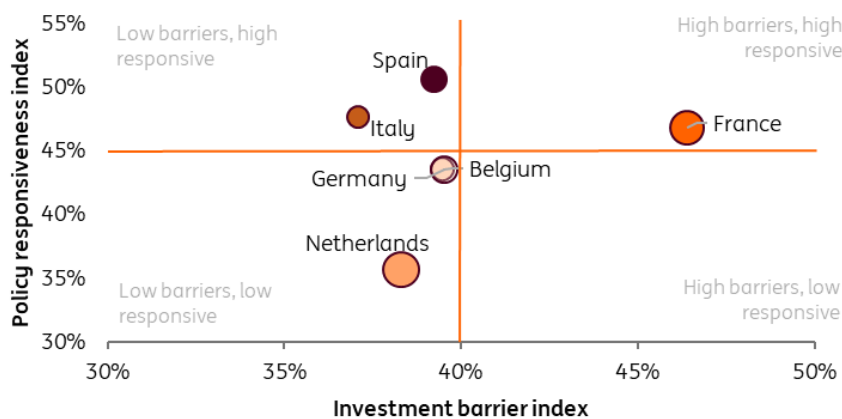
Turning willingness into investment

The rise in investment-fund flows suggests that Europe's investment landscape is already changing. Around one-third of respondents who do not currently invest say that they might do so in the future. Europe therefore has no shortage of potential investors. The challenge is to turn that potential into participation.

Our survey tested five possible ways of making that route easier: tax-free or tax-advantaged investment accounts, simpler investment products, lower-cost products, employer-based investment or pension schemes, and better access to independent financial advice. In some countries, like Spain and Italy, many say they would invest more if these changes were made. In others, like The Netherlands, few people say they would be more inclined to invest if policies were changed.

Turning potential investors into investors will require different solutions

Investment potential between countries, 2025



Source: Eurostat, ING Consumer Research

Note: The bubble size represents deposits as a share of total liquid assets. The orange shading indicates the share of respondents who indicate “might invest in shares, bonds, investment funds or ETFs”, with darker shades representing higher intention to invest. The policy responsiveness index is the simple average of share of respondents who say that each of five measures - tax-advantaged accounts, simpler products, lower-cost products, employer-based schemes and better access to independent financial advice - would make them more likely to invest or invest more. The investment barrier index is the simple average share reporting nine barriers related to insufficient savings, risk aversion, limited knowledge, costs, taxes, complexity, limited perceived need to invest, liquidity preferences and saving for a specific goal. Quadrants are divided based on means of the barriers.

Europe's investment gap is an opportunity for growth

The investment opportunity takes different forms across Europe. Spain combines a large pool of potential investors with relatively low barriers and strong responsiveness to the measures tested. Italy also looks well-placed to advance: many respondents might invest, obstacles are comparatively limited and the proposed measures receive a positive response. In both countries, the foundations for broader participation appear to be in place.

France and Germany offer scale but are harder to unlock. French households hold substantial amounts in deposits and respond comparatively well to the measures tested, despite high barriers and limited initial openness to investing. Germany also has a large pool of deposits, both in absolute terms and as a share of household wealth, but relatively few respondents say they might invest; reported barriers and policy responsiveness are closer to the European average. France may respond to stronger intervention, while Germany may require a broader shift in engagement as well as policy support.

Europe will not close its wealth gap with the United States overnight. But rising investment-fund flows and a large pool of potential investors show that the shift has already begun. The priority will differ across countries: some need to accelerate an existing move into investment, while others need stronger incentives and support to unlock savings still concentrated in deposits.

Helping more households invest an appropriate share of their savings could strengthen household wealth and, over time, support consumption, business financing and economic growth. Europe has savings and many households have the intention. The task now is to remove the specific barriers that prevent those intentions from being translated into action.

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Article | 9 September 2026

Europe's investment gap: why millions of savers remain on the sidelines

Europe is still largely a continent of savers, though a gradual shift is underway. Nearly three-quarters of households have savings, and around 4 in 10 Europeans already invest. Among savers, 30% are considering investing in the future, while half are already investors. Younger generations show notably greater openness to investing



Our survey results show that Europeans are open to investing, but are held back by risk aversion, a lack of knowledge and concerns around taxation

Contrary to popular belief, [Europeans have only recently turned into the super-savers](#) they are often portrayed as. But another widespread assumption holds true: [A much smaller portion of their financial assets is held in investments](#) compared to US households.

Policymakers want to turn saving-savvy Europeans into investors. The reasons for this are twofold: on the one hand, getting Europeans to invest would unlock significant capital that their economies could put to use. On the other, Europeans are missing out on a lot of potential wealth by saving too much and investing rather little. For the eurozone alone, our calculations show that shifting just five percentage points of household financial assets from deposits to investment funds [would have made households €1.17 trillion richer](#) over the 2002-2025 period. Given this, it is important to understand, if most households have the ability to save, why do so many stop there?

According to our survey, the answer lies in a combination of barriers. Some consumers are concerned about risk. Others feel they lack the necessary knowledge. Many believe they do not have sufficient resources available to invest. And a significant minority view taxation as an obstacle that reduces the attractiveness of investing altogether. It would appear that Europe is not uninterested in investing, but often uncertain about it.

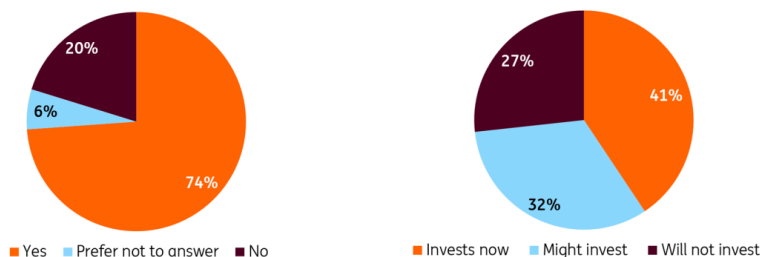
From saving to investing: focusing on those who might consider it

The distinction between saving and investing is more important than it may initially appear.

Saving is generally associated with security. Money remains accessible, risks appear limited, and outcomes are predictable. Investing requires a different mindset. It asks consumers to exchange certainty today for the possibility of higher returns in the future. However, people tend to place greater weight on potential losses than equivalent gains. Our survey results suggest that this dynamic continues to influence financial decision-making across Europe.

Most Europeans save, but only a minority invests

“Does your household have any savings?” and “Do you currently invest yourself in shares, bonds, investment funds or ETFs?”



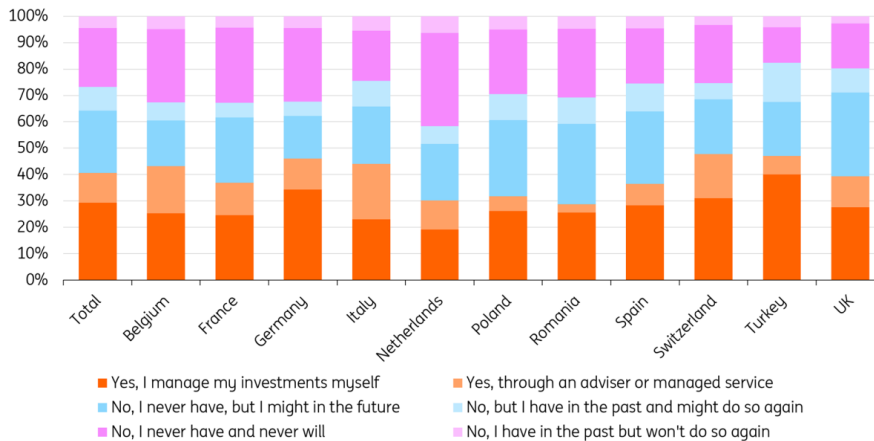
Source: ING Consumer Research

While 74% of respondents report having savings, only 41% currently invest. The result is a sizeable investment gap. Perhaps more importantly, it reveals a substantial pool of consumers who have accumulated financial resources but remain outside investment markets. Among those respondents with savings, around half of them currently invest. But another 31% of them say they might do so in the future.

Across all respondents, the share of potential investors is almost as large as the share of current investors. Approximately one third of respondents say they do not currently invest but could imagine doing so in the future, with numbers ranging from less than a quarter in Germany and Belgium to around 40% in Poland, Romania, Spain and the UK.

The Swiss, Germans, Italians and Belgians are Europe's leading investors

Investment participation by country



Source: ING Consumer Research

Note: Our survey results show higher percentages that say they currently invest than various available measures. This might partly be attributable to the fact that our survey is online-based – active internet users are more likely to follow the recent trend of trading through mobile apps. In addition to this, there might be methodological differences: Other measures might only count equity investors while our survey includes bondholders. And our results are expressed as a percentage of the adult population, not the total.

For policymakers, financial institutions and consumer organisations, this distinction matters. Potential investors differ clearly from convinced non-investors. Their hesitation appears to reflect barriers that may be overcome rather than a rejection of investing as a concept.

The survey suggests that European consumers can broadly be divided into three groups.

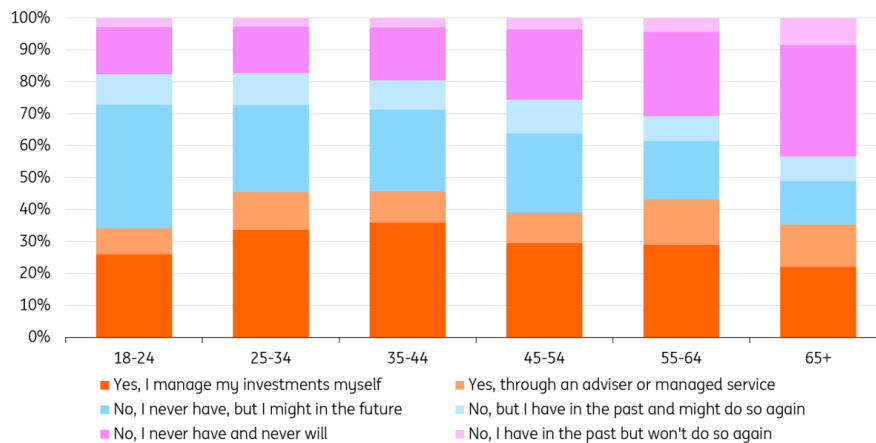
The first group consists of current investors. These respondents are generally more confident in their understanding of investments, more comfortable with risk and more likely to have higher incomes and levels of education. Among this group, concerns tend to focus less on whether to invest and more on practical considerations such as costs and taxation. These two aspects are among only a few that current investors consider more of a barrier than potential and non-investors.

The second group consists of potential investors. This segment may be the most interesting for Europe's stated ambition of getting households to invest more. These individuals do not currently invest, but they have not ruled it out. They are often younger than average: Firstly, respondents aged 25 to 44 display some of the highest levels of investment participation already. Secondly, younger adults that do not invest today are the most likely to say they

may invest in the future. This suggests a considerable amount of latent demand among younger Europeans and a corresponding uptick in future overall investment participation.

Untapped potential among the youngest

Investment participation by age group



Source: ING Consumer Research

The third group consists of non-investors who say they do not intend to invest. In addition to typically being older, this group is generally characterised by lower confidence, greater risk aversion and a stronger perception that investing is not relevant or appropriate for their circumstances. In many cases, they feel that they do not have the money necessary to start investing in the first place – 62% of non-investors say that the statement “My household has too little savings to invest” applies to them. For those that feel hindered by this aspect, there is fairly little that can be done short of putting more money in their pocket. This group will therefore not be the focus of our analysis.

The differences between these groups reveal an important insight. The challenge is not simply persuading non-investors to become investors. Rather, it is about focusing on the large group of consumers that remains stuck between intention and action. Given the importance for the economy and Europe’s stated objective of getting more households to invest, we’ll be looking into what is holding people back.

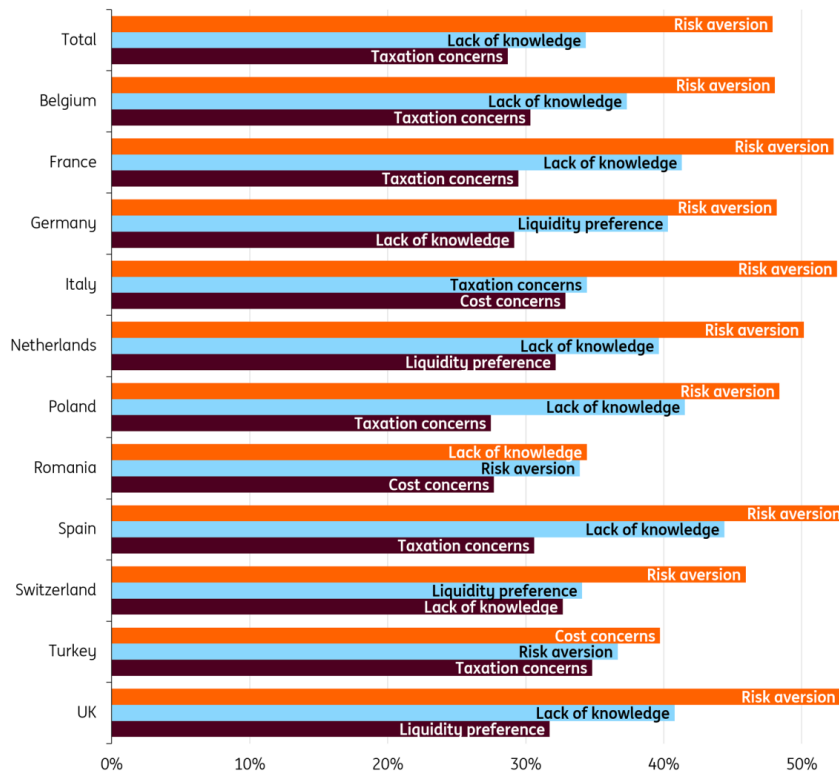
The barriers behind the hesitation: risk, knowledge, taxes

When excluding responses referring to simply not having the money, three barriers stand out for keeping people from investing across countries and demographic groups:

- The first is a reluctance to take investment risk.
- The second is a perceived lack of investment knowledge.
- The third is concern around taxation.

Risk aversion is top concern nearly everywhere

Ranked top-3 barriers by most current and potential investors per country



Source: ING Consumer Research

Excluding "Too little savings"

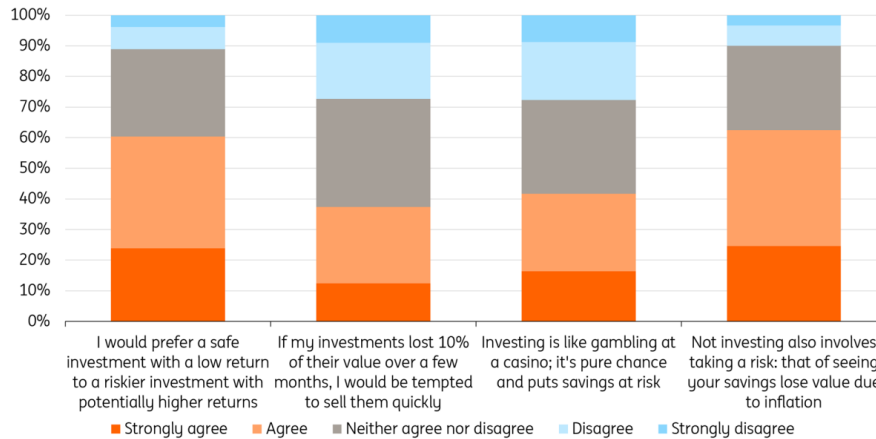
Risk aversion is widely cited as one of the most important barriers to investing – or to investing more than people currently do: 20% list it as the one factor that most prevents them from investing. More than half of all participants have it at least as one of their top three barriers; among those who don't currently invest, but might, the number is even higher.

Many view investing as pure chance

When it comes to risk, our survey also reveals an apparent contradiction in consumer attitudes towards risk. Many respondents agree with the principle that long-term investing requires accepting short-term fluctuations. Yet a substantial share also say they would be tempted to sell investments following a relatively modest market decline. And 42% – from 34% in Turkey to 50% in Poland – agree with a statement that compares investing to gambling at a casino and calls it "pure chance". Even 28% of current investors are in agreement.

Risk-averse, but well aware of inflation

Agreement and disagreement with statements around investment risk



Source: ING Consumer Research

Those numbers are quite striking – particularly because the statement in question is far from the truth. Investing might not provide the cozy security of a yearly account statement like saving does – but with a well-diversified approach and a sufficiently long time-horizon, risk can be lowered significantly. Measured in euro, the longest drawdown of the MSCI World, an index that serves as a basis for many passively managed exchange-traded funds (ETFs), was 13 years and 8 months following the dotcom crash in 2000. That certainly underlines what a long-term investment horizon really means: it may require more than a decade of patience.

It also means that historically, this index has never taken longer than that to climb back to its previous high. Of course, past performance is no guarantee of future returns.

Speaking of the dotcom crash, it probably played a role in shaping the “casino” connotation among those that are old enough to remember it; younger participants subscribe to that statement in lower numbers than older ones. A lower level of risk aversion and a higher willingness to see through fluctuations are also notable among younger generations – naturally so, as nearing retirement will usually shorten the time horizon and thus limit the possibility to make up for losses.

Selling at dips should be avoided, because it first realises a loss and then leaves the ex-investor on the outside looking in while share prices recover. But over a third of respondents say they would be tempted to do just that – for those that might invest, but don't currently, that number rises to 42%.

At the same time, 62% are aware that not investing also involves a risk: that of inflation eating up the interest payments (or more) on a savings account. Apparently, the inflationary experience of the past few years and the resulting higher inflation expectations have

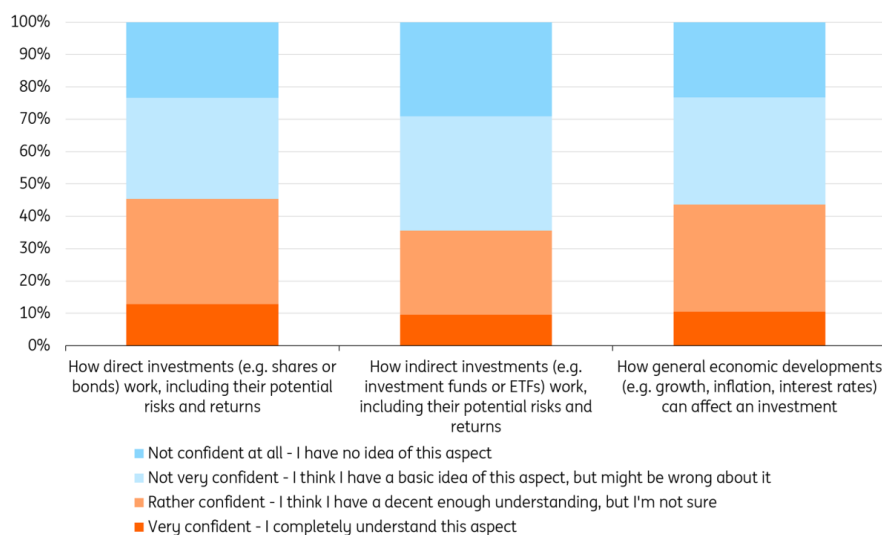
sharpened the eye for this aspect and could be a factor in getting more Europeans to invest.

Knowledge remains a critical factor

One of the strongest themes running through the survey is knowledge. Current investors consistently report higher levels of confidence in their understanding of how investments work and how they might be influenced by economic developments than both potential investors and non-investors.

Less than half feel confident about their investment knowledge

Reported confidence in knowledge around aspects of investments



Source: ING Consumer Research

But those people that report less confidence in their understanding of investments might not be aware of what they actually need to know. If you subscribe to the popular misconception of the stock market as a zero-sum game, where someone's gain is always someone else's loss, it's logical for you to think that you must beat the market in order to come away better off than before. You'll assume you have to be better than average at picking stocks and timing your sales and purchases.

That would indeed require a lot of knowledge. But it isn't true – [as we have shown](#), households' actual investments would have been good enough to make them considerably better off if they had just put more of their assets into them. Adhering to a few basic rules will set an investor up with a very good chance at long-term success:

- Invest with a long time horizon and only with money that you won't need during the foreseeable future.
- Don't put all eggs in one basket – diversify across geographies and industries.

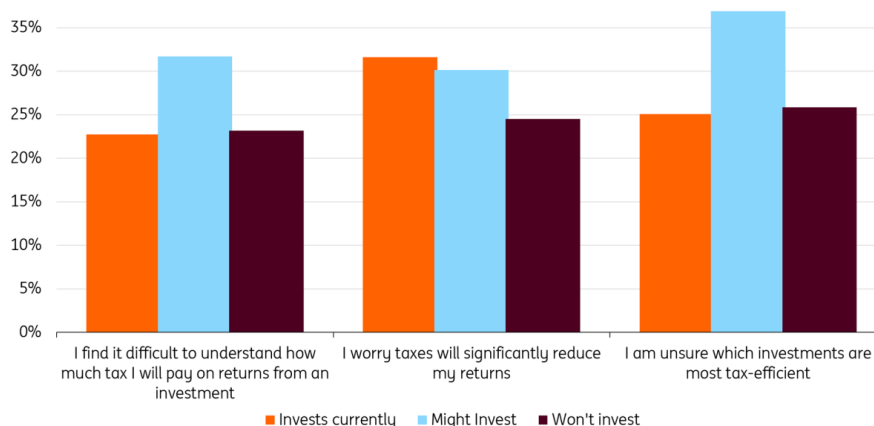
- Don't buy and sell a lot trying to get the timing right – instead, have the patience to see through dips.

How does taxation shape investment participation?

Although taxation is not the most frequently cited barrier, it occupies third place among the barriers considered for our analysis (excluding “My household has too little savings to invest”). In addition, 54% agree that “a tax-free or tax-advantaged investment account would make it more likely for me to invest (or invest more than I currently do)” – that’s considerably more than those that say the same thing about simpler or lower-cost investment products, employer-based schemes or better access to advice.

Taxes are misunderstood

Agreement with statements around aspects of taxation



Source: ING Consumer Research

Interestingly, taxation appears particularly relevant among consumers who are already relatively close to investing. Unlike savings constraints, which can prevent participation altogether, taxation concerns often arise later in the decision-making process. In other words, they may affect consumers who have already overcome some of the more fundamental barriers. This finding has broader implications.

Across Europe, efforts to encourage greater household participation in capital markets often focus on increasing financial literacy or reducing investment costs. That is important.

However, the survey suggests that (perceptions of) tax treatment also deserve attention. Consumers are more likely to engage with financial products when they feel able to understand the after-tax consequences of their decisions.

Cross-country comparisons and longitudinal studies clearly show that the design of taxation

and pension institutions can influence whether households invest, how they invest and how much they invest. There are ample examples of how institutional settings shape household behaviour.

- European [pay-as-you-go pension schemes](#) reduce the need for households to invest compared with the United States. Across our key markets, an average of 22% of respondents say they do not consider investing necessary because they believe they are well-prepared for the future, including retirement. At the same time, pay-as-you-go systems imply a higher tax burden. This may contribute to the 40% of respondents who say they have no money available to invest.
- The [Netherlands](#) shows how tax incentives and regulation can direct large amounts of household wealth into second-pillar pension funds. Dutch households rank among Europe's leading investors when pension assets are included. Their direct investments, however, remain below the European average, including relative to deposits. This may partly reflect the relatively large share of Dutch respondents, 30%, who say they do not need to invest because they are already well-prepared for the future.
- In Sweden, the [introduction of the tax-advantaged ISK](#) in 2012 was intended to encourage investment in funds and shares. By 2023, the number of unique account holders had increased more than fifteenfold, and over 80% of the assets were invested in equity or balanced funds. With the [increase in the tax-free limit in 2026](#), the government aims to broaden participation further.
- Denmark introduced its tax-advantaged stock savings account, the Aktiesparekonto, in 2019. The account has [grown by 38% per year](#), while other pension tax incentives have encouraged financially active households [to shift assets into tax-favoured retirement accounts](#).
- Policies not directly aimed at encouraging investment may still have an impact on household behaviour. In France, political instability, an ageing population, and an uncertain economic climate have raised financial savings rates. Some 77% note that uncertainty about future pensions means it is important to prepare for the future, and 80% also worry that high public debt today may put pressure on future pensions and the social security system. These concerns, coupled with the [decline in the Livret A rate \(government-regulated and tax-exempt traditional savings accounts\) starting in 2025](#) have pushed households to seek higher returns through unit-linked policies, [contributing to historic inflows into life insurance and annuity entitlements](#).
- In the United States, the employer-sponsored 401(k) retirement plan allows employees to invest part of their salary, with employers providing matching contributions up to a limit. [One study](#) finds that tax-advantaged catch-up provisions for older workers significantly increased their 401(k) contributions. Tax treatment is not the only factor, however. [Employer matching](#), [workplace access](#) and [automatic enrolment](#) also remain important.

The Netherlands, Sweden and Denmark stand out [among the few European countries that](#)

[offer tax advantages for investment](#). In these countries, incentives are comparable in scale to those available in the United States and relative to income, [household balance sheets are much more comparable to the United States](#).

And things are moving in Europe's largest economy: In 2027, Germany is due to introduce the new [Altersvorsorgedepot](#), which will allow households to invest in funds and ETFs for retirement with government contributions and tax-free growth during the accumulation phase.

Our survey suggests that such changes could matter. More than half of respondents agree that tax advantages would encourage them to start investing or to increase their existing investments. Taxation may not be the first barrier consumers mention, but the experience of other countries indicates that institutional design can influence whether intention turns into action.

Policymakers have a good basis to work from

After digging into the data and the surveys, we see a good basis to work from. We found a [high share of money going into savings](#), a recent [increase in money flowing into investment funds](#), and a gradual [increase in the importance of investments](#). We also found a substantial share of savers that would consider investing, especially among younger generations. It all brings us to a simple but important conclusion: Europe has the money and would consider investing.

Given these developments, we would expect to see a further uptick in the share of financial savings flowing into investments over time. But governments may want to give a further push, given the importance for both households and the broader economy. They have two types of levers.

Firstly, and most likely to lead to significant shifts, they can change institutions, similar to what happened in Sweden. Germany is in the process of doing that, which will have an impact from next year onwards. These interventions will mostly be national policies and can include taxation, automatic enrolment and a shift from pay-as-you-go to capital-funded pension schemes.

Another type of lever is about how people think and talk about risks and knowledge. As economists, we believe that Europeans do not understand investing in the right way, when a large share sees it like a casino. We don't see investing as something people do against each other or against the market – beating or timing it is not the aim. We would explain investing the way Schumpeter taught us to see it, more than a century ago: as the provision of risk-bearing capital, which enables firms to undertake productive investments that drive innovation and productivity growth. Over a sufficiently long time horizon, this leads to profits and higher wages, hence the return for investors, while also supporting societies more broadly (where we

obviously acknowledge that institutions matter greatly, both for enabling innovation as for translating it into broad-based sustainable growth).

For Europeans to benefit more from this principle, it would help to make investing both simpler and less stressful. For that, all people have to know are the three rules of thumb: a long time horizon, diversification and minimal trading generally generate the best returns over time.

We conclude here with a glass half full perspective. An important shift is underway: Europe's savers are gradually becoming investors. European policymakers are working on speeding it up. That supports both households as well as future economic growth.

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Article | 9 September 2026

FX

FX Daily: Dollar price action quite poor

Despite higher energy prices and firm short-dated US interest rates, the dollar remains soft. Wild swings in USD/JPY remain the main event, but the benign, low-volatility investment environment is another key factor encouraging flows out of the dollar. The calendar is quiet today and the focus will probably return to US Treasuries ahead of auctions



➔ USD: Dollar should be doing better

Dollar price action this week has been a little disappointing/confusing. Higher energy prices due to an escalation in the Gulf will direct more trade flows towards the US at the expense of Europe and Asia. At the same time, US short-dated rates remain relatively elevated as they await Friday's US August CPI release – what should be the final piece of the puzzle for the Fed's policy decision next week. We are expecting a 25bp Fed rate hike.

The fact that the dollar is not stronger may be attributable to both the investment environment and to developments in USD/JPY. On the former, global equity markets remain near their peaks as the AI investment boom keeps global growth relatively resilient. As mentioned earlier this week, one of the tightest FX correlations out there is the negative one between equities and the dollar. A very fragile USD/JPY is probably also contributing to the dollar malaise, as global macro hedge funds position for a downside break of 150 over the coming months on expectations that Japanese policymakers will deliver on their side of some

grand bargain with Washington.

There is also the question of whether buy-side investors are quietly raising their dollar hedge ratios. Certainly, the most recent data we have seen this summer suggest the European buy-side has been running relatively low FX hedge ratios on US assets – a position which could be challenged in investment committee meetings as they consider more activist US Treasury policy. On that front, the bond market will be in focus today as the US Treasury starts its buy-back operation of longer-dated Treasuries, plus auctions \$39bn and \$22bn of 10 and 30-year bonds today and tomorrow, respectively.

We don't fully understand why the dollar is not reacting to higher energy prices and do not see a strong case for DXY to immediately break support at 98.55/65. If it were to break, we suspect USD/JPY would be the driver, and a quick drop in DXY to 98.00 could be seen.

Chris Turner

➔ **EUR: Mid range**

Near 1.1600, EUR/USD is sitting approximately in the middle of its range seen since April. As above, we would have thought that the clear decline in the euro's terms of trade would be an important factor weighing on EUR/USD this week. The fact that it is holding up quite well probably raises more questions for the dollar.

Our team published their [ECB cheat sheet](#) yesterday. Unlike the market, we are looking for a dovish hike – or at least a hike which does not support the additional 50bp of tightening priced in after Thursday's expected 25bp move.

The eurozone calendar is very quiet today. We do not quite see a justification for EUR/USD to break above resistance at 1.1640/45, but if so, 1.1675/80 beckons. At present, we prefer a [1.15 end-September target](#) on the back of a Fed hike.

Chris Turner

⬇ **PLN: Hawkish pricing leaves room for correction**

We expect [the Polish central bank to keep rates unchanged](#) at 3.75% today, as renewed tensions in the Middle East and higher oil prices leave little scope for easing. National Bank of Poland Governor Adam Glapiński sounded dovish in July and was open to post-summer rate cuts. However, subsequent developments suggest his inflation outlook was too optimistic, with inflation likely to rebound towards the upper end of the tolerance band later this year.

The Polish market shifted hawkish in August alongside global markets and now prices around 80bp of tightening, similar to the Czech Republic. However, the Czech National Bank remains notably more hawkish than the NBP. Unless the NBP surprises today or tomorrow, some

repricing is likely. Oil and gas prices will continue to support hawkish bets, but a partial dovish correction could lift EUR/PLN back above 4.330 soon.

Frantisek Taborsky

BRL: Narrowing polls help the real

USD/BRL is drifting towards the lower end of its two-month range at 5.05/5.07, helped by the latest opinion polls for October's presidential election. For the first time yesterday, a poll put challenger Flavio Bolsonaro ahead of President Lula in a second-round run-off. Polymarket still shows President Lula's chances of winning as some 7% ahead of Bolsonaro, but the gap is closing fast. Those overweight the Brazilian real will be hoping for some kind of Colombian peso-style advance should Bolsonaro be successful and bring in some fiscal consolidation and deregulation.

Clearly, the benign global investment environment is also helping the real, which is backed by one of the highest real interest rates in the world. At the very least, we look for the real to continue outperforming the steep forward curve, if not deliver nominal appreciation should the polls shift even further to Bolsonaro.

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Article | 9 September 2026

RATES

Rates Spark: Sterling's hawkish pricing still looks overdone

UK rates look too hawkish relative to Bank of England guidance and macro fundamentals. But oil sensitivity and fiscal uncertainty are sustaining a sizeable risk premium, complicating the near-term expression of our structurally bullish view



Bank of England Governor Andrew Bailey has pushed back against the idea of multiple hikes as priced in by the GBP curve

Oil price uncertainty and fiscal risks complicate an otherwise bullish structural outlook for UK rates

Sterling rates continue to reflect a very hawkish narrative and seem overdone relative to central bank communications and macro fundamentals. In parliament on Tuesday, Bank of England Governor Andrew Bailey pushed back against the idea of multiple hikes as priced in by the GBP curve. And this is not the first time the Bank of England has struck a much more dovish tone than markets' positioning. The question is whether markets are genuinely expecting almost three hikes over the next year or whether we are dealing with some form of risk premium. We think the latter.

Sterling rates show high sensitivity to oil prices, which means any bet on GBP rates is also a bet on Trump's next move. Since the start of the conflict in the Middle East, every \$10 increase in

Brent added around 15bp to 2Y rates, more than the 11bp for EUR and 8bp for USD rates.

In addition, the new Labour government adds budget-related risks. We don't expect a material fiscal expansion, but we cannot fully dismiss the probability either. More government spending would delay Bank of England cuts, and according to markets, even add more hikes.

So whilst we take a structurally bullish view on sterling rates, trading this view in the near term remains a challenge. We also believe many market players face the same issue, explaining why sterling rates seem to bear a significant risk premium. Only once the predictability of oil prices improves do we see scope for tactical opportunities. But with oil likely to test \$100 again, we stay on the sidelines.

Wednesday's events and market view

There is not much data on Wednesday, in theory leaving the markets to be mostly dictated by geopolitical headlines and energy prices.

On long-end US yields, the Treasury's announcement of the 10-20y buyback operations will receive more attention. Recall, in a surprise move in August, the Treasury had announced to at least double its long-end buyback operations – a size announcement of US\$4bn would thus mark the bare minimum. Note also that the announcement comes just two hours ahead of the Treasury's 10y note auction.

In Europe, Germany will sell €5.5bn in 10y Bunds and Portugal will tap 3y, 8y and 9y bonds for up to €1.75bn in total.

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